
DAV Chapter 246

Official Veterans Resource Guide

Tarrant County, Texas

2026-2027 Edition

Helping Veterans and Their Families Access the Benefits They've Earned

Prepared for the veterans, service members, families, survivors, and caregivers of Tarrant County, Texas.

Published by:

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Chapter 246

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The information in this guide is intended to help veterans, military service members, family members, caregivers, and survivors locate benefits and services available in Tarrant County, the State of Texas, and through the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs (VA).

Every effort has been made to verify the information contained in this publication using official government agencies, the Department of Veterans Affairs, the Texas Veterans Commission, Tarrant County, and recognized nonprofit organizations. Because programs, eligibility requirements, office locations, phone numbers, and operating hours may change, readers are encouraged to verify current information before making decisions or submitting applications.

This guide is provided as an educational and informational resource and should not be considered legal or financial advice.

When assistance with VA disability claims, appeals, or veterans benefits is needed, veterans are encouraged to contact **Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Chapter 246** for free accredited claims assistance.

No veteran should ever pay a fee to file a VA disability claim with an accredited Veterans Service Organization.

Welcome

Welcome to the DAV Chapter 246 Veterans Resource Guide

To every veteran, active duty service member, National Guard member, Reservist, family member, caregiver, and survivor:

Thank you for your service to our nation.

Whether you served for four years or twenty, during peace or war, your service matters. The benefits available through the Department of Veterans Affairs and the State of Texas were earned through that service.

Unfortunately, many veterans never receive the benefits they qualify for because they do not know where to begin, believe they are not eligible, or assume the process is too complicated.

This guide was created to change that.

Inside these pages you will find trusted information about healthcare, disability compensation, education, employment, housing, mental health services, financial assistance, transportation, caregiver support, and many other programs available throughout Tarrant County.

Whenever you need help filing a VA disability claim or understanding your earned benefits, DAV Chapter 246 is here to help at no cost.

Our mission is simple:

Veterans helping veterans.

About Disabled American Veterans (DAV)

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) is a nonprofit veterans service organization founded in 1920. For more than a century, DAV has helped millions of veterans and their families access the benefits they earned through military service.

DAV's mission is to empower veterans to lead high-quality lives with respect and dignity by ensuring they receive the care, benefits, and opportunities they have earned.

DAV provides free assistance with:

- VA disability compensation claims
- PACT Act claims
- Appeals and Higher-Level Reviews
- Survivor and dependency benefits
- Healthcare enrollment
- Employment resources
- Transportation assistance
- Advocacy for veterans and their families

Accredited DAV Service Officers provide claims assistance free of charge. Membership is not required to receive help with filing VA claims.

About DAV Chapter 246

Veterans Helping Veterans in Tarrant County

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Chapter 246 proudly serves veterans, their families, caregivers, and survivors throughout Tarrant County and the surrounding communities.

Our chapter is committed to one purpose: helping veterans receive the benefits, services, and respect they earned through military service.

Whether you recently separated from the military or served decades ago, our team is here to help you navigate the VA system and connect you with trusted local resources.

Free VA Claims Assistance

DAV Chapter 246 provides free accredited assistance with:

- Initial VA disability claims
- PACT Act claims
- Toxic Exposure (TERA) claims
- Agent Orange claims

- Burn Pit claims
- Gulf War claims
- PTSD claims
- Military Sexual Trauma (MST) claims
- Supplemental Claims
- Higher-Level Reviews
- Board of Veterans' Appeals
- Dependency claims
- Survivor benefits
- Healthcare enrollment guidance

DAV never charges veterans for claims assistance.

You do not have to be a DAV member to receive assistance with your VA claim.

Our Commitment

Every veteran deserves:

- Respect
- Honest guidance
- Accurate information
- Professional assistance
- Compassion throughout the claims process

Our volunteers and accredited service officers work to help veterans obtain every benefit they have earned under federal and state law.

Before You Visit DAV

Bringing the right documents can help speed up your appointment.

If available, bring:

- DD Form 214
- Government-issued photo ID
- Social Security card
- VA decision letters
- Medical records
- Private medical records related to your condition

- Marriage certificate (if applicable)
- Divorce decree (if applicable)
- Birth certificates for dependent children (if applicable)
- Direct deposit information
- Any correspondence received from the VA

If you do not have every document, do not delay contacting DAV. We can help you determine what is needed and where to obtain missing records.

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Chapter 1

Understanding VA Disability Compensation

What Is VA Disability Compensation?

VA disability compensation is a tax-free monthly benefit paid to veterans who have disabilities, illnesses, or medical conditions that were caused or made worse by their military service.

Compensation is based on the severity of a service-connected condition, known as a **disability rating**, which ranges from **0% to 100%** in 10% increments.

Depending on your disability rating and family situation, you may also qualify for additional benefits, including:

- Monthly disability compensation
- VA health care
- Dental benefits
- Vision care
- Prescription coverage
- Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (VR&E)
- Education benefits
- Adaptive housing grants

- Automobile grants
- Clothing allowance
- Caregiver support
- Dependents' educational assistance
- Property tax exemptions available through the State of Texas
- Commissary and exchange privileges for eligible veterans
- Burial and memorial benefits

Start With DAV

If you think you may qualify for VA disability compensation, your first step should be to contact **DAV Chapter 246**.

An accredited DAV Service Officer can review your military service, medical history, and supporting documentation, explain which benefits may apply to your situation, and help prepare and submit your claim at no cost.

The next section will walk veterans through the entire claims process, from determining eligibility and gathering evidence to filing a successful claim and understanding what to expect after submission. This chapter will become one of the most detailed and practical sections of the guide.

Filing Your First VA Disability Claim

For many veterans, filing a VA disability claim can seem overwhelming. The process involves medical records, military service records, evidence, and forms that can be difficult to understand without guidance.

The good news is that you do not have to navigate the process alone.

DAV Chapter 246 provides free assistance from accredited Service Officers who help veterans prepare and submit claims, gather supporting evidence, and respond to VA requests throughout the process.

Who May Qualify?

You may be eligible for VA disability compensation if all three of the following are true:

- You served on active duty, active duty for training (in certain cases), or inactive duty training (in certain cases).
- You have a current medical condition, illness, or disability.
- There is a connection between your military service and your current condition.

This connection is known as a **service connection**.

The Three Elements of a Successful Claim

Nearly every VA disability claim must establish three key elements:

1. A Current Diagnosis

The VA generally requires evidence that you currently have the medical condition for which you are seeking benefits.

Examples include:

- Arthritis
- Back injuries
- Hearing loss
- Tinnitus
- Sleep apnea
- PTSD
- Migraines
- Knee injuries
- Anxiety
- Depression
- Diabetes
- Cancer
- Asthma
- Hypertension

A diagnosis may come from a VA provider or a qualified private healthcare provider.

2. An In-Service Event, Injury, or Exposure

Your claim should identify what occurred during military service that caused or contributed to your condition.

Examples include:

- Combat injuries
- Training accidents
- Aircraft noise

- Weapons fire
- Burn pit exposure
- Agent Orange exposure
- Toxic chemicals
- Military Sexual Trauma (MST)
- Falls
- Vehicle accidents
- Repetitive physical stress
- Hazardous materials
- Environmental hazards

Supporting evidence may include military records, deployment records, service treatment records, incident reports, buddy statements, photographs, or other documentation.

3. A Medical Link (Nexus)

The VA generally needs evidence connecting your current medical condition to your military service.

This connection may be established through:

- Service treatment records.
- Medical opinions.
- VA Compensation & Pension (C&P) examinations.
- Private medical opinions.
- Presumptive service connection for qualifying conditions.
- Other evidence accepted under VA regulations.

A DAV Service Officer can help identify what evidence may strengthen your claim.

Before You File

Taking time to prepare can help your claim move more smoothly.

Gather Important Documents

If available, collect:

- DD Form 214 or other separation documents.
- Government-issued photo identification.

- Service treatment records.
- Private medical records.
- VA medical records.
- Current medication list.
- Names and addresses of healthcare providers.
- Marriage certificate, if applicable.
- Divorce decree, if applicable.
- Birth certificates for dependent children.
- Direct deposit information.

Do not delay seeking assistance if you are missing records. Many documents can be requested or obtained with help from DAV or other official agencies.

Your First Appointment with DAV

During your appointment, an accredited DAV Service Officer may:

- Review your military service history.
- Discuss your medical conditions.
- Explain potential VA benefits.
- Identify evidence that may support your claim.
- Help complete required VA forms.
- Answer questions about the claims process.
- Explain what happens after your claim is submitted.

Appointments are provided at no cost.

What Happens After You File?

After your claim is submitted, the VA typically:

1. Receives and acknowledges your claim.
2. Reviews the evidence submitted.
3. Requests additional information if needed.
4. Schedules Compensation & Pension (C&P) examinations when appropriate.
5. Reviews all available evidence.
6. Issues a decision.
7. Explains any benefits awarded or the reasons for any denial.

Processing times vary depending on the complexity of the claim and the evidence available.

Veteran Tip

File as soon as you believe you may be eligible. Waiting months or years to begin the process can delay benefits. Even if you are unsure whether you qualify, meeting with an accredited DAV Service Officer can help you understand your options and determine the best path forward.

Next section: *Understanding VA Disability Ratings (0% through 100%), how ratings are determined, and how they affect compensation and other federal and Texas veterans benefits.*

Understanding VA Disability Ratings

One of the first questions many veterans ask is, "What percentage will I receive?"

The Department of Veterans Affairs assigns a disability rating based on how much a service-connected condition affects your overall health and ability to function. Ratings are assigned in **10% increments**, from **0% to 100%**.

Your rating determines not only your monthly disability compensation but may also affect eligibility for many other federal and Texas veterans benefits.

What Does a Disability Rating Mean?

A VA disability rating represents the severity of a service-connected condition.

Ratings may include:

- 0%
- 10%
- 20%
- 30%
- 40%
- 50%

- 60%
- 70%
- 80%
- 90%
- 100%

A veteran may receive one rating for a single condition or multiple ratings for different conditions. The VA combines ratings using a formula established by law rather than simply adding percentages together.

A 0% Rating Still Matters

Many veterans believe a 0% rating means they were denied benefits.

That is not correct.

A 0% disability rating means the VA has recognized that your condition is service connected, even though it is not currently severe enough to qualify for monthly compensation.

A 0% rating can still provide important protections and may make it easier to request an increased rating if the condition worsens in the future.

Conditions Can Change

Many service-connected disabilities become more severe over time.

Examples include:

- Arthritis
- Back injuries
- Hearing loss
- PTSD
- Knee injuries
- Migraines
- Respiratory illnesses
- Diabetes complications

If your condition worsens, you may be able to request an increased disability rating.

DAV Chapter 246 can assist veterans with filing claims for increased evaluations.

Combined Ratings

Many veterans have more than one service-connected disability.

For example:

- Hearing loss
- Tinnitus
- Knee injury
- PTSD
- Back condition

The VA does **not** simply add the percentages together. Instead, it uses the Combined Ratings Table established by federal regulation.

Because this calculation can be confusing, an accredited DAV Service Officer can help explain how combined ratings work and what benefits may be available.

Benefits That May Increase With Higher Ratings

As disability ratings increase, veterans may become eligible for additional federal and state benefits.

Depending on the individual veteran's circumstances, these benefits may include:

- Higher monthly disability compensation.
- Additional compensation for eligible dependents.
- Expanded VA health care eligibility.
- Dental care for eligible veterans.
- Vision care.
- Adaptive housing grants.
- Automobile and adaptive equipment assistance.
- Clothing allowance.
- Caregiver support.
- Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (VR&E).
- Commissary and exchange privileges for eligible veterans.

- Texas property tax exemptions for qualifying disabled veterans.
- Hunting and fishing license benefits under Texas law.
- State park benefits and other Texas veteran programs.

Eligibility requirements vary by benefit and should always be confirmed before applying.

Total Disability Based on Individual Unemployability (TDIU)

Some veterans cannot maintain substantially gainful employment because of their service-connected disabilities, even if their combined rating is less than 100%.

In certain cases, the VA may grant **Total Disability Based on Individual Unemployability (TDIU)**, allowing eligible veterans to receive compensation at the 100% disability rate.

If your disabilities prevent you from working, discuss your situation with an accredited DAV Service Officer to determine whether TDIU may be an option.

Understanding Effective Dates

An effective date is the date the VA uses to determine when benefits begin.

In many cases, the effective date is tied to the date your claim was received, although there are important exceptions.

Because effective dates can significantly affect retroactive benefits, veterans should file claims promptly and seek assistance if they believe an earlier effective date may apply.

Veteran Tip

Do not assume you are ineligible because another veteran received a different rating for a similar condition. Every claim is decided based on the individual veteran's medical evidence, military service, and applicable law.

Why Work With DAV?

Navigating the VA disability system can be challenging, especially when multiple medical conditions or appeals are involved.

DAV Chapter 246 provides free accredited assistance to help veterans:

- Understand disability ratings.
- Review VA decision letters.
- File for increased ratings.
- Submit supplemental claims.
- Request Higher-Level Reviews.
- Appeal unfavorable decisions.
- Identify additional benefits that may be available.

There is never a fee for claims assistance provided by DAV.

Next Chapter

The PACT Act and Toxic Exposure Benefits

This chapter will explain:

- Who qualifies under the PACT Act.
- Presumptive conditions.
- Burn pit exposure.
- Agent Orange.
- Gulf War exposures.
- Other toxic exposure claims.
- What evidence veterans should bring.
- How DAV Chapter 246 can assist with filing these claims.

The PACT Act

Expanding Benefits for Veterans Exposed to Toxic Substances

The Sergeant First Class Heath Robinson Honoring our Promise to Address Comprehensive Toxics (PACT) Act is one of the largest expansions of VA health care and disability benefits in recent history.

The law helps veterans who were exposed to toxic substances during military service receive the health care and disability benefits they earned.

Many veterans who were previously denied benefits, or who never filed a claim, may now qualify under the PACT Act.

If you served in certain locations or were exposed to specific environmental hazards, you should speak with an accredited DAV Service Officer to determine whether you may now be eligible.

Who Should Consider Filing?

You should consider speaking with DAV Chapter 246 if you served:

- In Iraq.
- In Afghanistan.
- During the Gulf War.
- In Vietnam.
- In Thailand during qualifying periods.
- At certain military installations with documented toxic exposure.
- Near burn pits.
- Around hazardous chemicals.
- In areas with airborne environmental hazards.
- In locations identified by the VA as qualifying under the PACT Act.

Even if you filed a claim years ago and were denied, recent changes in the law may affect your eligibility.

What Is Toxic Exposure?

Military service often places service members in environments that contain hazardous substances.

Examples include:

- Burn pit smoke.

- Agent Orange.
- Airborne particulate matter.
- Fine dust.
- Oil well fires.
- Industrial chemicals.
- Jet fuel.
- Asbestos.
- Lead.
- Radiation.
- Contaminated drinking water.
- Other environmental hazards recognized by the VA.

Exposure does not automatically qualify a veteran for benefits, but it may establish eligibility when combined with other requirements under current VA regulations.

Presumptive Conditions

For certain veterans, the VA presumes that specific illnesses are connected to military service based on where and when they served.

This is called **presumptive service connection**.

When a condition is presumptive, veterans generally do not have to prove the exposure itself if they meet the applicable service requirements.

Presumptive conditions vary depending on the type of exposure and the veteran's service history.

Because these lists change as laws and regulations evolve, veterans should consult DAV Chapter 246 or the VA for the most current information.

Burn Pit Exposure

Burn pits were commonly used during military operations to dispose of waste materials.

Items burned often included:

- Plastics.
- Fuel.

- Paint.
- Medical waste.
- Chemicals.
- Electronics.
- Human waste.
- Other refuse.

Veterans who served near burn pits and later developed certain illnesses may now qualify for benefits under the PACT Act.

Agent Orange

Many Vietnam-era veterans, along with certain veterans who served in other qualifying locations and time periods, may be eligible for presumptive benefits related to Agent Orange exposure.

If you served during the Vietnam era or believe you were exposed to herbicides during military service, DAV Chapter 246 can help determine whether current VA regulations apply to your claim.

Gulf War and Southwest Asia Veterans

Veterans who served in Southwest Asia or surrounding operational areas may qualify for benefits related to environmental exposures or medically unexplained chronic illnesses recognized by the VA.

These claims can involve multiple factors, including deployment history, symptoms, and current medical evidence.

What Should You Bring?

When meeting with DAV about a PACT Act claim, bring as many of the following items as possible:

- DD Form 214.
- Government-issued photo ID.

- VA decision letters.
- Medical records.
- Private medical records.
- List of current medications.
- Deployment history.
- Documentation of duty locations, if available.
- Any correspondence from the VA regarding previous claims.

Do not delay scheduling an appointment if you are missing records. DAV can help identify what additional documentation may be needed.

If You Were Previously Denied

A previous denial does not necessarily mean you are no longer eligible.

Changes in federal law, new medical evidence, or updated VA regulations may allow some veterans to reopen or pursue benefits through a supplemental claim or another review option.

An accredited DAV Service Officer can review your previous decision and explain what options may now be available.

Veteran Tip

If you served in an area known for toxic exposure and now have a chronic illness, do not assume the VA already has all of your information. Schedule a claims review with DAV Chapter 246. A review of your service history and medical records may identify benefits you have not yet claimed.

Next Chapter

Compensation & Pension (C&P) Examinations

This chapter will explain what to expect during a VA C&P examination, how to prepare, common mistakes veterans make, and practical guidance to help veterans present accurate information during the examination process.

Compensation & Pension (C&P) Examinations

Understanding Your C&P Exam

A Compensation & Pension (C&P) examination is one of the most important steps in many VA disability claims.

The purpose of the examination is **not to provide medical treatment**, but to help the VA evaluate your claimed condition and determine whether it is connected to your military service and how severe it is.

A C&P examination may be conducted by a VA clinician or by a contracted medical provider on behalf of the VA.

Not every claim requires a C&P examination, but many do.

Why the VA Schedules a C&P Exam

The VA may schedule an examination to:

- Confirm a current diagnosis.
- Evaluate the severity of your condition.
- Determine whether your condition is related to military service.
- Assess how your disability affects your daily life.
- Review new medical evidence.
- Evaluate requests for increased disability ratings.

The examiner does not make the final benefits decision. The VA reviews the examination along with all other evidence before issuing a decision.

Before Your Appointment

Preparation can make your examination go more smoothly.

Before your appointment:

- Review your claimed conditions.
 - Read your medical records if available.
 - Bring your government-issued identification.
 - Arrive early.
 - Wear clothing appropriate for any physical examination.
 - Bring hearing aids, glasses, braces, or mobility devices if you normally use them.
 - Review your symptoms so you can describe them accurately.
-

During the Examination

The examination will vary depending on your claimed conditions.

The examiner may:

- Ask about your military service.
- Discuss when your symptoms began.
- Ask how often symptoms occur.
- Review medications.
- Ask about work history.
- Ask how your condition affects everyday activities.
- Perform physical measurements.
- Review range of motion.
- Conduct hearing or vision testing.
- Discuss mental health symptoms when applicable.

Answer every question honestly and completely.

Describe Your Worst Days

Many disabilities fluctuate.

Some days may be manageable while others are extremely difficult.

When discussing your condition:

- Explain how symptoms affect you on both good and bad days.
- Describe limitations accurately.
- Mention pain, fatigue, dizziness, memory problems, or other symptoms when they occur.

- Explain how your condition affects work, driving, sleeping, family life, hobbies, and daily activities.

Do not exaggerate your symptoms.

Do not minimize them either.

The goal is to provide an accurate picture of how your disability affects your life.

Common Mistakes Veterans Make

Many veterans unintentionally weaken their claims by:

- Saying "I'm fine" when they are struggling.
- Forgetting to mention important symptoms.
- Downplaying pain because they are accustomed to living with it.
- Assuming the examiner has already reviewed every medical record.
- Missing the appointment.
- Failing to update contact information.
- Ignoring requests from the VA for additional evidence.

Being honest, prepared, and thorough can help ensure the examiner has the information needed to complete an accurate evaluation.

If You Need to Reschedule

If you cannot attend your examination, contact the scheduling office as soon as possible.

Missing a C&P examination without good cause may delay your claim or result in a decision based on the evidence already available.

After the Examination

After your appointment:

1. The examiner prepares a report.
2. The report is sent to the VA.
3. The VA reviews all evidence.
4. A rating specialist makes a decision.
5. You receive a decision letter explaining the outcome.

Processing times vary depending on the complexity of your claim.

Veteran Tip

A C&P examination is one part of your claim, not the entire claim. Your service records, medical records, supporting statements, and other evidence are also considered by the VA when making a decision.

If you have questions before or after your examination, contact **DAV Chapter 246**. An accredited Service Officer can explain the process and help you understand the next steps.

Common Reasons Claims Are Denied

Receiving a denial can be frustrating, but it does not always mean your claim is over. Many denials result from missing evidence, incomplete documentation, or legal requirements that were not fully met.

Some of the most common reasons include:

- No current medical diagnosis.
- Insufficient evidence connecting the condition to military service.
- Missing medical records.
- Missed C&P examination.
- Incomplete application.
- Lack of supporting documentation.
- The condition does not meet the legal requirements for service connection.

A denial should be carefully reviewed to understand the reason before deciding what action to take.

If Your Claim Is Denied

If the VA denies your claim, you may have several review options depending on your situation and the applicable VA rules.

These may include:

- Filing a Supplemental Claim with new and relevant evidence.
- Requesting a Higher-Level Review.
- Appealing to the Board of Veterans' Appeals.

Each option has different requirements and deadlines.

Before taking action, have your VA decision letter reviewed by an accredited **DAV Chapter 246 Service Officer**, who can explain the available options and help determine the most appropriate next step.

Next Chapter

Appeals and Decision Review Options

This chapter will explain Supplemental Claims, Higher-Level Reviews, Board Appeals, important filing deadlines, and practical guidance for veterans seeking review of an unfavorable VA decision.

Appeals and Decision Review Options

Receiving a VA decision is not always the end of the claims process. If your claim is denied, or if you disagree with the disability rating or effective date assigned by the VA, you have the right to request a review.

Many successful claims are approved after additional evidence is submitted or an error is identified during the review process.

DAV Chapter 246 provides free assistance in reviewing VA decision letters and helping veterans determine the most appropriate next step.

Read Your Decision Letter Carefully

When the VA issues a decision, you will receive a written notification explaining:

- The conditions that were approved.
- The conditions that were denied.
- Your disability rating.
- Your effective date.
- The evidence the VA considered.
- The reasons for each decision.
- Your review options.

Do not assume a denial means you are not eligible for benefits. In many cases, additional evidence or a different review option may change the outcome.

Supplemental Claims

A Supplemental Claim allows you to submit **new and relevant evidence** that was not previously considered by the VA.

Examples of new evidence may include:

- Recently obtained medical records.
- A new medical diagnosis.
- A private medical opinion.
- Service records that were not previously available.
- Buddy statements.
- Additional documentation supporting your claim.

A Supplemental Claim gives the VA another opportunity to review your case based on the additional evidence.

Higher-Level Review

If you believe the VA made an error when reviewing the evidence already submitted, you may request a Higher-Level Review.

During this process:

- No new evidence is submitted.
- A more experienced VA reviewer conducts a fresh review of the existing record.
- The reviewer determines whether an error occurred during the original decision.

This option may be appropriate when you believe the law or evidence was applied incorrectly.

Board of Veterans' Appeals

If you disagree with the VA's decision after other review options, you may appeal to the Board of Veterans' Appeals.

Board Appeals involve review by a Veterans Law Judge.

Depending on the type of appeal selected, veterans may:

- Request review based on the existing record.
- Submit additional evidence.
- Request a hearing before a Veterans Law Judge.

Board Appeals are generally more formal and may take longer than other review options.

An accredited DAV Service Officer can help explain the available appeal options and assist with the process.

Effective Dates Matter

Sometimes the issue is not whether benefits were granted, but **when** they begin.

The effective date determines when compensation starts and may affect the amount of retroactive benefits owed.

If you believe the VA assigned the wrong effective date, discuss your decision letter with DAV Chapter 246 before filing a review request.

Increased Rating Claims

Service-connected disabilities can worsen over time.

If your condition has become more severe since your last VA decision, you may qualify for an increased disability rating.

Examples include:

- Increased pain.
- Reduced mobility.
- More frequent migraines.
- Worsening PTSD symptoms.
- Additional surgeries.
- New complications related to a service-connected disability.

Supporting medical evidence is often important when requesting an increased evaluation.

Secondary Service Connection

Some disabilities develop because of another service-connected condition.

For example:

- Knee injuries contributing to hip or back problems.
- Diabetes leading to neuropathy.
- PTSD contributing to sleep disorders.
- Orthopedic conditions resulting in depression or anxiety.

These are known as **secondary service-connected conditions** and may qualify for additional disability compensation when supported by appropriate evidence.

Keep Copies of Everything

Maintain a personal file containing:

- VA decision letters.
- Medical records.
- Service records.
- Forms submitted to the VA.
- Appointment notes.

- Correspondence.
- Receipts for certified mail, if applicable.

Keeping organized records can make future claims and appeals much easier.

Veteran Tip

Do not ignore deadlines. If you receive a VA decision that you disagree with, contact DAV Chapter 246 as soon as possible. Reviewing your options early may help preserve important appeal rights.

VA Claims Checklist

Before submitting any VA disability claim, review this checklist:

- ✓ DD Form 214 or equivalent separation documents
- ✓ Government-issued photo ID
- ✓ Current medical diagnosis
- ✓ Medical records supporting your claim
- ✓ Service treatment records, if available
- ✓ List of current medications
- ✓ Names and addresses of healthcare providers
- ✓ Marriage certificate, if claiming eligible dependents
- ✓ Birth certificates for dependent children, if applicable
- ✓ Bank account information for direct deposit
- ✓ Copies of previous VA decision letters
- ✓ Supporting statements or buddy letters, if available
- ✓ Contact information for DAV Chapter 246

Chapter Summary

By now you should understand:

- How VA disability compensation works.
- What evidence is needed for a claim.
- The importance of service connection.
- How disability ratings are determined.
- The PACT Act and toxic exposure benefits.
- What to expect during a C&P examination.
- The options available if the VA denies your claim.

If you are unsure where to begin, schedule an appointment with **DAV Chapter 246**. Accredited Service Officers provide free assistance and can help you understand your options, prepare your claim, and navigate the VA benefits system.

Chapter 2 Preview: VA Health Care

The next chapter will focus on VA health care available to veterans in Tarrant County, including:

- Enrolling in VA health care.
- VA North Texas Health Care System.
- Fort Worth VA Clinic.
- Mansfield VA Clinic.
- Specialty care services.
- Pharmacy and prescriptions.
- Urgent care.
- Women's health.
- Telehealth.
- Eligibility and enrollment.
- Local maps, contact information, and QR codes to official VA resources.

This next chapter will be heavily localized so veterans can quickly find the care available closest to them.

Chapter 2

VA Health Care

Your Health Care Benefits Through the Department of Veterans Affairs

The VA provides comprehensive health care to eligible veterans through one of the nation's largest integrated health care systems. In North Texas, eligible veterans are served by the **VA North Texas Health Care System**, which includes the Fort Worth VA Clinic and other nearby facilities. ([TexVet](#))

VA health care includes much more than routine doctor visits. Depending on your eligibility, you may have access to:

- Primary care
- Specialty medical care
- Mental health services
- Women's health
- Laboratory services
- Imaging
- Physical therapy
- Pharmacy services
- Telehealth
- Preventive care
- Hearing and audiology
- Nutrition counseling
- Social work services
- Caregiver support
- Home-based care
- Hospice and palliative care

Many veterans qualify for services even if they do not have a service-connected disability. Eligibility depends on factors such as military service, discharge status, income, disability rating, and other criteria established by the VA.

Enrolling in VA Health Care

If you have never enrolled in VA health care, the first step is to submit an enrollment application.

You may enroll:

- Online through the official VA website.
- By phone with the VA.
- In person at a VA medical facility.
- With assistance from an accredited DAV Service Officer.

To help speed the enrollment process, have the following available:

- DD Form 214 or equivalent discharge documentation.
- Government-issued photo ID.
- Social Security number.
- Health insurance information, if applicable.
- Financial information, if requested by the VA.

If you are unsure whether you qualify, apply anyway or speak with DAV Chapter 246. Many veterans are eligible for services they did not realize were available.

VA North Texas Health Care System

The VA North Texas Health Care System serves veterans across North Texas through a network of hospitals and outpatient clinics. It is one of the VA's largest health care systems and provides primary, specialty, rehabilitation, and mental health services to veterans throughout the region.

([TexVet](#))

Fort Worth VA Clinic

For many veterans living in Tarrant County, the **Fort Worth VA Clinic** is the primary location for routine health care.

Address

2201 Southeast Loop 820
Fort Worth, TX 76119

The clinic offers services including:

- Primary care
- Laboratory services
- Gastroenterology
- Mental health
- Audiology
- Physical therapy
- Pharmacy
- Preventive care
- Specialty referrals
- Telehealth support

The clinic is generally open Monday through Friday during regular business hours, although hours may vary by department. Veterans should confirm appointment times before visiting. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Appointments

Veterans can schedule, reschedule, or cancel appointments by contacting the VA appointment line or their care team.

Before your appointment:

- Arrive early.
- Bring a photo ID.
- Bring your VA health identification card, if you have one.
- Bring an updated medication list.
- Bring any outside medical records that may assist your provider.

If you cannot attend your appointment, notify the clinic as soon as possible so another veteran can use that appointment time.

Primary Care

Primary care providers coordinate your overall health care.

Your primary care team may help with:

- Annual wellness visits

- Preventive screenings
- Chronic disease management
- Blood pressure
- Diabetes management
- Cholesterol management
- Vaccinations
- Medication management
- Referrals to specialists

Your primary care provider is often your first point of contact for additional VA services.

Specialty Care

Some medical conditions require treatment from specialists.

Depending on your medical needs and eligibility, VA North Texas offers access to specialties such as:

- Cardiology
- Gastroenterology
- Neurology
- Orthopedics
- Dermatology
- Pulmonology
- Endocrinology
- Urology
- Oncology
- Physical Medicine and Rehabilitation
- Pain Management

Some specialty services require a referral from your primary care provider. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Laboratory and Diagnostic Services

Veterans may receive laboratory testing and other diagnostic services ordered by their VA provider.

These may include:

- Blood work
- Urinalysis
- Diagnostic imaging
- Electrocardiograms (EKGs)
- Other medically necessary testing

Your provider will explain any preparation required before your appointment.

Veteran Tip

If you are new to the VA health care system, schedule a primary care appointment even if you feel healthy. Establishing care early makes it easier to access specialty care, preventive services, and future treatment when you need it.

Next section: *Pharmacy Services, Prescriptions, Urgent Care, Telehealth, Women's Health, Mental Health, and local Tarrant County clinics, followed by a two-page quick reference with maps, phone numbers, and QR codes to official VA resources.*

Pharmacy Services

VA pharmacy benefits help eligible veterans receive prescription medications ordered by their VA health care providers. Most maintenance medications can be refilled online or by phone and are mailed directly to your home, while new prescriptions can often be picked up at VA outpatient pharmacies. Veterans should request refills at least 10 days before running out of medication. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

The Fort Worth VA Clinic includes an outpatient pharmacy for new prescriptions written by VA providers. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Tips for Managing Your Prescriptions

- Keep an updated list of all medications.
- Request refills before your supply runs low.
- Tell your VA provider about medications prescribed outside the VA.
- Ask your pharmacist if you have questions about dosage or side effects.
- Safely dispose of expired medications using VA MedSafe collection boxes when available. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Telehealth

Not every appointment requires an in-person visit.

VA Telehealth allows many veterans to receive care from home using a phone, tablet, or computer. Depending on your medical needs, telehealth appointments may be available for:

- Primary care
- Mental health counseling
- Medication follow-up
- Nutrition counseling
- Diabetes management
- Some specialty consultations
- Caregiver support

Telehealth can reduce travel time while helping veterans stay connected with their care team.
([Veterans Affairs](#))

Women's Health

Women are one of the fastest-growing veteran populations, and VA North Texas offers comprehensive health care designed specifically for women veterans.

Services include:

- Women's primary care
- Annual wellness exams
- Gynecology
- Maternity care coordination
- Mammograms
- Cervical cancer screening
- Family planning
- Menopause care
- Mental health services
- Military Sexual Trauma (MST) care
- Lifestyle and wellness programs

Each woman veteran can work with a Women Veterans Program Manager or Care Coordinator to help navigate available services and coordinate care. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Mental Health Services

Mental health is an essential part of overall health.

VA North Texas provides confidential treatment for a wide range of concerns, including:

- PTSD
- Depression
- Anxiety
- Grief
- Substance use disorders
- Trauma
- Sleep disorders
- Military Sexual Trauma (MST)
- Suicide prevention

Many services are available through outpatient clinics, specialty programs, and telehealth. Same-day help may also be available for veterans experiencing urgent mental health concerns. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Urgent Care and Emergency Care

If you believe your life or health is in immediate danger:

Call 911 or go to the nearest emergency room immediately.

For urgent medical issues that are not life threatening, eligible veterans may qualify for VA-authorized community urgent care under certain circumstances. Contact the VA or your care team if you are unsure where to seek treatment. The VA North Texas emergency department operates 24 hours a day for emergency care at its medical center. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC)

After enrolling in VA health care, eligible veterans may receive a Veteran Health Identification Card.

Your VHIC may be used to:

- Check in for appointments.
- Verify your identity at VA facilities.
- Access certain VA services.

Bring your VHIC and a government-issued photo ID whenever possible when visiting a VA facility.

Caregiver Support

Family members and caregivers play an important role in helping veterans remain healthy and independent.

VA caregiver resources may include:

- Caregiver education
- Support groups
- Care coordination
- Respite services
- Referrals to community resources

Additional caregiver programs are covered in a later chapter of this guide.

Veteran Tip

Choose one VA primary care provider and keep your medical care coordinated whenever possible. Regular appointments, medication reviews, and preventive screenings can help identify health concerns early and improve long-term outcomes.

Quick Reference

VA North Texas Health Care System

Provides comprehensive medical care, specialty care, mental health services, pharmacy, rehabilitation, telehealth, women's health, caregiver support, and many additional services for eligible veterans throughout North Texas. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Fort Worth VA Clinic

Address

2201 Southeast Loop 820
Fort Worth, TX 76119

Common Services

- Primary Care
- Laboratory
- Pharmacy
- Gastroenterology
- Audiology
- Physical Therapy
- Mental Health
- Specialty Referrals
- Telehealth

The clinic is generally open Monday through Friday from **8:00 a.m. to 4:30 p.m.**, although individual service hours may vary. Veterans should verify appointments and clinic hours before visiting. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Chapter 2 Summary

By now you should understand:

- How to enroll in VA health care.
- The services available through VA North Texas.
- What the Fort Worth VA Clinic provides.
- How to refill prescriptions.
- How telehealth works.
- Women's health resources.
- Mental health services.
- When to seek urgent or emergency care.

If you need help enrolling in VA health care or understanding your eligibility, **DAV Chapter 246** can help connect you with the appropriate VA resources while also assisting with any disability claims or benefits questions.

Chapter 3

Mental Health & Emotional Wellness

You Are Not Alone

Military service can have lasting effects on emotional and mental well-being. Some veterans experience these challenges immediately after leaving the military, while others may not notice symptoms until years later.

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not weakness.

The VA and many organizations throughout Tarrant County provide confidential, evidence-based mental health services for veterans and their families. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

If You Are in Crisis

If you believe you or someone else is in immediate danger:

Call 911 immediately.

If you are experiencing emotional distress, thoughts of suicide, or a mental health crisis:

Veterans Crisis Line

- Call **988**, then press **1**
- Text **838255**
- Chat online through the official Veterans Crisis Line website

The Veterans Crisis Line is available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, at no cost for veterans, service members, National Guard, Reserve members, and their loved ones. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Common Mental Health Conditions

Veterans may experience a wide range of mental health concerns, including:

- Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)
- Depression
- Anxiety
- Panic attacks
- Military Sexual Trauma (MST)
- Grief
- Survivor's guilt
- Substance use disorders
- Sleep disorders
- Traumatic Brain Injury (TBI)-related emotional symptoms
- Anger and irritability
- Relationship challenges

These conditions are common and treatable.

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

PTSD can develop after experiencing or witnessing traumatic events during military service.

Symptoms may include:

- Nightmares
- Flashbacks
- Hypervigilance
- Difficulty sleeping
- Avoiding reminders of traumatic events
- Emotional numbness
- Irritability
- Difficulty concentrating

The VA offers several evidence-based treatments, including Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT), Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT), and Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR). ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Military Sexual Trauma (MST)

Military Sexual Trauma includes sexual assault or repeated, threatening sexual harassment experienced during military service.

Veterans who experienced MST may receive counseling and related care through the VA, even if they are not enrolled in VA health care or do not have a service-connected disability for MST. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Available services may include:

- Individual counseling
- Group counseling
- Trauma-focused therapy
- Psychiatric care
- Referrals to additional community resources

All care is confidential.

Fort Worth Vet Center

The **Fort Worth Vet Center** provides community-based counseling in a smaller, non-medical setting that many veterans find more comfortable than a hospital environment.

Services include:

- Individual counseling
- Group counseling
- PTSD treatment
- Military Sexual Trauma counseling
- Bereavement counseling
- Family counseling
- Transition assistance
- Referrals to VA benefits and community resources

Many veterans are eligible for Vet Center services even if they are not enrolled in VA health care. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

VA North Texas Mental Health

VA North Texas operates a comprehensive behavioral health program offering both inpatient and outpatient services.

Programs include:

- Psychiatry
- Psychology
- Addiction treatment
- PTSD treatment
- Homeless veteran services
- Returning veteran transition programs
- Tele-mental health
- Care coordination

Veterans can also contact the VA North Texas Mental Health One Number to be connected with mental health specialists. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Peer Support

Sometimes the best person to talk to is another veteran.

Peer support programs connect veterans who have faced similar challenges and understand military culture.

Peer specialists can help veterans:

- Navigate VA services
- Find local resources
- Build community
- Reduce isolation
- Stay engaged in recovery

MHMR of Tarrant County's Military Veteran Peer Network offers veteran peer support, housing assistance referrals, transportation assistance, and mentoring throughout the community. ([My Health My Resources of Tarrant County](#))

Substance Use Recovery

If alcohol or drug use has become difficult to manage, help is available.

Treatment options may include:

- Outpatient counseling
- Residential treatment
- Medication-assisted treatment
- Recovery support groups
- Peer mentoring
- Family counseling

The Fort Worth Vet Center and VA North Texas can connect veterans with treatment programs based on their individual needs. ([Veterans Affairs](#))

Helping a Fellow Veteran

If you notice a fellow veteran struggling:

- Reach out.
- Listen without judgment.
- Encourage professional help.
- Offer to accompany them to an appointment.
- Call the Veterans Crisis Line if there is concern for immediate safety.

Sometimes one conversation can change a life.

Veteran Tip

You do not need to face PTSD, depression, anxiety, addiction, or grief alone. Asking for help is one of the strongest decisions a veteran can make, and treatment works. Thousands of veterans recover every year with the right support.

Next Chapter

Housing, Homelessness & Emergency Assistance

This chapter will cover:

- HUD-VASH housing vouchers
- Emergency shelters
- Transitional housing
- Patriot House
- Catholic Charities Fort Worth
- Volunteers of America Texas
- Presbyterian Night Shelter
- Emergency rent and utility assistance
- Homeless prevention programs
- Tarrant County housing resources
- What to do if you are at immediate risk of homelessness

Chapter 4

Housing, Homelessness & Emergency Assistance

Every Veteran Deserves a Safe Place to Call Home

Stable housing is the foundation for good health, employment, financial stability, and recovery. Veterans facing housing insecurity are not alone. Federal, state, county, and nonprofit organizations throughout Tarrant County work together to help veterans prevent homelessness, secure temporary shelter, and find permanent housing.

Whether you are behind on rent, living with friends or family, sleeping in your vehicle, or currently experiencing homelessness, help is available.

Many housing programs also provide case management, employment assistance, mental health services, and long-term support to help veterans remain housed.

Are You at Immediate Risk?

If you answer **yes** to any of the following questions, contact a housing resource as soon as possible.

- Have you received an eviction notice?
- Are you currently sleeping outside or in your vehicle?
- Are you staying in a shelter?
- Are you moving from place to place because you have nowhere permanent to live?
- Are your utilities scheduled for disconnection?
- Have you recently lost your job and cannot pay rent?
- Are you leaving a hospital, jail, or treatment program without housing?

Do not wait until you have nowhere to go. Many programs are designed to prevent homelessness before it occurs.

HUD-VASH Program

Housing Choice Vouchers for Eligible Veterans

The HUD-VASH (Housing and Urban Development-Veterans Affairs Supportive Housing) program combines rental assistance with VA case management for eligible veterans experiencing homelessness.

Veterans approved for HUD-VASH may receive:

- Long-term rental assistance
- Help locating housing
- Ongoing case management
- Health care coordination
- Mental health services

- Employment referrals
- Community support services

Eligibility is determined by the VA and housing authority based on program requirements and individual circumstances.

If you believe you may qualify, contact the VA Homeless Programs Office or speak with DAV Chapter 246 for assistance locating the appropriate point of contact.

VA Homeless Programs

The Department of Veterans Affairs offers several programs designed to prevent and end veteran homelessness.

These programs may include:

- Emergency housing assistance
- Transitional housing
- Permanent supportive housing
- Case management
- Health care
- Employment assistance
- Legal referrals
- Financial counseling

Veterans do not need to wait until they are living on the street before seeking help.

Supportive Services for Veteran Families (SSVF)

The Supportive Services for Veteran Families (SSVF) program helps eligible low-income veteran households remain stably housed or quickly obtain permanent housing.

Services may include:

- Rental assistance
- Security deposits
- Utility assistance

- Moving expenses
- Case management
- Benefits assistance
- Employment referrals
- Budget counseling

SSVF is intended to prevent homelessness whenever possible and to rapidly rehouse veterans who have already lost housing.

Catholic Charities Fort Worth

Catholic Charities Fort Worth assists veterans and other community members through a variety of emergency assistance programs.

Depending on funding and eligibility, services may include:

- Emergency rent assistance
- Utility assistance
- Case management
- Financial coaching
- Food assistance
- Community referrals

Programs and funding availability may change throughout the year.

Presbyterian Night Shelter

Presbyterian Night Shelter provides emergency shelter and supportive services for individuals experiencing homelessness in Fort Worth.

Veterans may also receive referrals to specialized veteran housing programs and partner agencies.

Services may include:

- Emergency shelter
- Meals
- Showers
- Case management

- Housing navigation
 - Employment assistance
 - Connections to VA programs
-

Volunteers of America Texas

Volunteers of America Texas provides housing and supportive services for veterans throughout Texas.

Programs may include:

- Transitional housing
- Permanent supportive housing
- Employment services
- Case management
- Behavioral health referrals
- Recovery support

Eligibility requirements vary by program.

Patriot House

Patriot House serves veterans transitioning from homelessness or other difficult circumstances by providing structured housing and supportive services.

Programs often include:

- Safe housing
- Peer support
- Recovery resources
- Employment assistance
- Financial coaching
- Community reintegration

Availability depends on program capacity and eligibility.

What to Bring When Applying for Housing Assistance

Having documents ready may help speed up the application process.

If available, bring:

- DD Form 214
- Government-issued photo ID
- Social Security card
- Proof of income
- Bank statements
- Lease agreement
- Eviction notice (if applicable)
- Utility shutoff notice (if applicable)
- VA identification card
- Medical documentation if requesting disability-related accommodations

If you do not have every document, apply anyway. Many agencies can help you obtain missing paperwork.

Veteran Tip

Housing assistance programs often have waiting lists. If you believe you may lose your housing in the coming weeks or months, seek assistance immediately rather than waiting until you have nowhere to stay.

Quick Reference

If You Need Housing Today

1. Contact the VA Homeless Programs Office.
2. Call 2-1-1 Texas to locate emergency assistance in your area.
3. Contact Catholic Charities Fort Worth for available assistance.
4. Contact Presbyterian Night Shelter if emergency shelter is needed.

5. Contact DAV Chapter 246 for guidance and referrals to veteran-specific housing resources.
-

Emergency Financial Assistance

Unexpected financial hardship can affect any veteran. Job loss, illness, injury, or family emergencies may make it difficult to pay for housing, utilities, food, or transportation.

Several organizations throughout Tarrant County provide temporary financial assistance to eligible veterans and their families.

Depending on available funding and program requirements, assistance may include:

- Rent payments
- Mortgage assistance
- Utility payments
- Food assistance
- Transportation assistance
- Emergency lodging
- Case management
- Financial counseling

Most programs require documentation of military service and proof of financial need.

Utility Assistance

If you are struggling to keep electricity, water, or natural gas connected, seek assistance before service is disconnected.

Several community organizations may provide:

- Electric bill assistance
- Water bill assistance
- Natural gas assistance
- Payment plans
- Energy conservation resources
- Emergency financial assistance

Funding is often limited and may be available on a first-come, first-served basis.

Food Assistance

No veteran should have to choose between paying bills and buying groceries.

Tarrant County offers numerous food resources for veterans, seniors, and military families.

Examples include:

Mission Arlington

Provides emergency food assistance, clothing, household items, and additional support services for individuals and families in need.

Tarrant Area Food Bank

Works with community partners throughout Tarrant County to distribute groceries through food pantries, mobile food distributions, and senior nutrition programs.

Salvation Army

May provide emergency food boxes, meals, financial assistance, and referrals to additional community resources.

Community Churches and Local Food Pantries

Many churches and nonprofit organizations operate neighborhood food pantries that welcome veterans regardless of military branch.

Availability varies by location.

2-1-1 Texas

One of the most valuable resources available to veterans is **2-1-1 Texas**.

By calling **2-1-1**, veterans can be connected with local assistance programs for:

- Housing
- Food

- Utility assistance
- Mental health services
- Transportation
- Legal assistance
- Senior services
- Disability resources
- Childcare
- Employment assistance

Specialists can help identify programs based on your ZIP code and personal situation.

Preventing Eviction

If you have received an eviction notice:

Do not ignore it.

Take action immediately.

Recommended steps include:

1. Contact your landlord as soon as possible.
2. Contact a veteran assistance organization.
3. Apply for available rental assistance.
4. Keep copies of all notices and court documents.
5. Contact DAV Chapter 246 for referrals to veteran-specific resources.

Early action often provides more options than waiting until a court date has been scheduled.

Housing Resources for Women Veterans

Women veterans may have unique housing needs, particularly those with children or those leaving unsafe living situations.

Several organizations offer:

- Family housing
- Transitional housing
- Emergency shelter

- Domestic violence assistance
- Mental health counseling
- Childcare referrals

Women veterans should also speak with the VA Women Veterans Program for additional support and care coordination.

Housing Resources for Veteran Families

Veterans with spouses, children, or dependent family members may qualify for family-focused housing assistance.

Programs may include:

- Family emergency shelters
- Rental assistance
- Utility assistance
- Permanent supportive housing
- Case management
- School support for children
- Financial counseling

Eligibility requirements vary by program.

Financial Planning After Housing Is Secured

Obtaining housing is only the first step.

Long-term housing stability often depends on:

- Creating a monthly budget.
- Building an emergency savings fund.
- Paying rent on time.
- Maintaining communication with landlords.
- Keeping important documents organized.
- Continuing employment or education.

- Connecting with VA and community support programs.

Many organizations offer free financial coaching and budgeting assistance.

Frequently Asked Questions

I am sleeping in my car. Should I wait until I am completely homeless before asking for help?

No. Contact a housing resource immediately. Many programs are designed to prevent homelessness before it becomes more severe.

I was denied housing assistance before. Can I apply again?

Possibly. Eligibility requirements and available funding change over time. A previous denial does not necessarily prevent future assistance.

I have children. Are there programs for families?

Yes. Several organizations provide emergency housing and supportive services for veterans with spouses and dependent children.

I do not have my DD-214. Can I still ask for help?

Yes. Many organizations can begin assisting you while helping you obtain missing military records.

Veteran Tip

If you are facing multiple challenges, such as housing, unemployment, and medical issues, ask to work with a case manager. Case managers can help coordinate services across several organizations instead of requiring you to navigate each program separately.

Chapter 4 Summary

This chapter introduced:

- HUD-VASH
- VA Homeless Programs
- Supportive Services for Veteran Families (SSVF)
- Emergency shelters
- Rental assistance
- Utility assistance
- Food resources
- Women veteran housing resources
- Family housing programs
- Eviction prevention
- Financial stability planning

No veteran should face homelessness alone. If you or another veteran is struggling with housing, reach out early. Assistance is available, and many programs are designed to help veterans regain stable housing before a crisis becomes permanent.

Chapter 5

Employment, Careers & Small Business Resources

Building Your Next Mission

Military service develops leadership, discipline, teamwork, technical skills, and problem-solving abilities that are highly valued in today's workforce. Whether you are transitioning from active duty, changing careers, returning to work after an injury, or starting your own business, numerous programs are available to help veterans succeed.

Employment is more than earning a paycheck. Meaningful work provides stability, purpose, financial independence, and opportunities to continue serving your community.

Throughout Tarrant County, veterans have access to specialized employment counselors, career training, education benefits, apprenticeship programs, and business development resources created specifically for those who served.

Texas Veterans Commission Employment Services

The Texas Veterans Commission (TVC) provides employment services to veterans and eligible spouses through Workforce Solutions offices across Texas.

Veteran Employment Representatives can assist with:

- Career planning
- Resume development
- Interview preparation
- Job search assistance
- Skills assessments
- Employment workshops
- Federal employment guidance
- Transition assistance
- Employer connections

These services are provided at no cost.

Workforce Solutions for Tarrant County

Workforce Solutions for Tarrant County connects veterans with employment opportunities throughout North Texas.

Services may include:

- Job placement assistance
- Career counseling
- Skills training
- Workforce certifications
- Computer access
- Hiring events
- Apprenticeship opportunities
- Labor market information
- Career coaching

Veterans should identify themselves when registering to ensure they receive veteran priority of service when applicable.

Veteran Priority of Service

Federal law provides eligible veterans and certain spouses with Priority of Service for many Department of Labor funded employment and training programs.

Priority of Service generally means veterans receive access to employment resources before non-veterans when programs have limited availability.

Ask employment specialists whether Priority of Service applies to the program you are seeking.

Federal Employment

Many federal agencies actively recruit veterans.

Veterans may qualify for:

- Veterans' Preference
- Special hiring authorities
- Disabled veteran hiring programs
- Direct hire opportunities
- Internship programs
- Career development opportunities

Federal careers are available in nearly every professional field including healthcare, cybersecurity, law enforcement, engineering, finance, logistics, education, administration, and information technology.

Resume Development

Military experience often translates into valuable civilian skills.

A strong resume should clearly explain:

- Leadership experience
- Technical training

- Certifications
- Project management
- Equipment operation
- Security clearances
- Awards and achievements
- Volunteer experience

Avoid using military acronyms that civilian employers may not recognize.

Instead, describe your accomplishments using language understood by both public and private employers.

Interview Preparation

Interviews provide an opportunity to explain how military experience applies to civilian employment.

Helpful preparation includes:

- Researching the employer.
- Practicing common interview questions.
- Preparing examples of leadership.
- Demonstrating teamwork experience.
- Explaining technical skills.
- Discussing problem-solving abilities.
- Dressing professionally.
- Arriving early.

Confidence comes from preparation.

Apprenticeships and Skilled Trades

Many veterans pursue careers through registered apprenticeship programs.

These programs combine classroom instruction with paid on-the-job training.

Popular fields include:

- Electrician

- HVAC
- Plumbing
- Welding
- Construction
- Manufacturing
- Information Technology
- Cybersecurity
- Automotive Technology
- Commercial Driving

Apprenticeships allow veterans to earn income while developing new professional skills.

Higher Education and Professional Certifications

Many careers require additional education or industry certifications.

Veterans may use earned education benefits for:

- College degrees
- Trade schools
- Professional certifications
- Licensing examinations
- Technical training
- Continuing education
- Online learning

Education benefits are discussed in greater detail in Chapter 6.

Hire Heroes USA

Hire Heroes USA is a national nonprofit organization that assists veterans, transitioning service members, and military spouses with career development.

Services include:

- Resume assistance

- Career coaching
- Interview preparation
- Job search guidance
- Employer networking

Many veterans find these services valuable when entering the civilian workforce.

Veterans Business Outreach Center

Many veterans choose entrepreneurship instead of traditional employment.

Veterans Business Outreach Centers (VBOCs) help veterans:

- Evaluate business ideas
- Write business plans
- Understand financing options
- Access business training
- Learn government contracting opportunities
- Connect with mentors

Owning a business allows many veterans to continue serving their communities while building financial independence.

Starting Your Own Business

Launching a business requires planning and commitment.

Important steps include:

- Choosing a business structure
- Registering the business
- Obtaining required licenses
- Opening business bank accounts
- Purchasing insurance
- Creating a marketing strategy
- Understanding tax obligations
- Developing a financial plan

Organizations throughout Texas provide free counseling for veteran entrepreneurs.

Employment Rights Under USERRA

The Uniformed Services Employment and Reemployment Rights Act (USERRA) protects employment rights for service members returning from military duty.

USERRA generally protects eligible service members from employment discrimination based on military service and provides certain reemployment rights after qualifying periods of military duty.

Veterans who believe their employment rights have been violated should seek guidance from the appropriate federal agency or a qualified legal professional.

Employment Resources for Disabled Veterans

Veterans with service-connected disabilities may qualify for additional employment assistance.

Programs may include:

- Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment (VR&E)
- Workplace accommodations
- Career counseling
- Job placement services
- Assistive technology
- Skills training
- Independent living services for eligible veterans

These programs are designed to help veterans achieve meaningful employment consistent with their abilities and career goals.

Veteran Success Tips

- Keep your resume updated.
- Continue learning through training and certifications.
- Build a professional network.

- Attend veteran hiring events.
 - Take advantage of free career counseling.
 - Practice interviewing regularly.
 - Be open to new industries.
 - Highlight leadership and teamwork experience.
 - Never underestimate the value of your military service.
-

Quick Reference

Organizations That Can Help

Texas Veterans Commission

- Veteran employment counseling
- Resume assistance
- Career coaching
- Employer connections

Workforce Solutions for Tarrant County

- Job search assistance
- Training programs
- Hiring events
- Workforce development

Hire Heroes USA

- Resume reviews
- Career coaching
- Interview preparation

Veterans Business Outreach Center

- Business planning
- Entrepreneurship training
- Small business counseling
- Veteran business resources

Whether your goal is finding your first civilian job, changing careers, earning a professional certification, or building your own company, Tarrant County offers a wide network of organizations committed to helping veterans achieve long-term career success.

Chapter 6

Education, Training & Lifelong Learning

Investing in Your Future

Education is one of the most valuable benefits earned through military service. Whether your goal is earning a college degree, learning a skilled trade, obtaining a professional certification, or changing careers, numerous education programs are available to help veterans achieve their goals.

Federal and Texas education benefits can significantly reduce or eliminate the cost of tuition, books, training, and licensing exams.

Many veterans use these benefits immediately after leaving military service, while others return to school years later to pursue new career opportunities.

It is never too late to invest in your education.

GI Bill®

The GI Bill is one of the most recognized veterans benefits in the United States.

Depending on your eligibility, GI Bill benefits may be used for:

- College degrees
- Community college
- Technical schools
- Trade schools
- Apprenticeships
- Flight training
- On-the-job training
- Graduate degrees
- Professional certifications
- Licensing examinations
- Certain online education programs

Benefits vary depending on the specific GI Bill program and individual eligibility.

Before selecting a school or training program, confirm that it has been approved for VA education benefits.

Post-9/11 GI Bill

Many veterans who served after September 10, 2001 may qualify for benefits under the Post-9/11 GI Bill.

Depending on eligibility, benefits may include:

- Tuition assistance
- Monthly housing allowance
- Annual book and supply stipend
- Payments directly to participating schools
- Benefits for approved training programs

Some veterans may also qualify to transfer education benefits to eligible dependents if all program requirements are met.

Montgomery GI Bill

Some veterans may qualify for benefits under the Montgomery GI Bill.

Benefits may be used for:

- Degree programs
- Certificate programs
- Apprenticeships
- Flight training
- Correspondence courses
- Vocational education

Eligibility depends upon military service history and program requirements.

Hazlewood Act

The Texas Hazlewood Act is a state education benefit available to eligible Texas veterans.

For qualifying veterans, the program may provide up to **150 credit hours** of tuition exemption at eligible Texas public colleges and universities.

The Hazlewood Act generally applies to tuition but does not automatically cover books, fees, or housing expenses.

Some veterans may also qualify to transfer unused Hazlewood hours to eligible dependent children through the Hazlewood Legacy Program.

Eligibility requirements are established by Texas law.

Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E)

Formerly known as Vocational Rehabilitation and Employment, the Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E) program helps eligible veterans with service-connected disabilities prepare for, obtain, and maintain suitable employment.

Depending on individual needs, VR&E services may include:

- Career counseling
- Education planning
- College or vocational training
- Professional certifications
- Employment assistance
- Resume development
- Job placement
- Independent living services for eligible veterans

VR&E counselors work closely with veterans to create individualized rehabilitation plans based on career goals and abilities.

Colleges and Universities in Tarrant County

Veterans have access to outstanding educational institutions throughout Tarrant County and the surrounding region.

Popular options include:

Tarrant County College (TCC)

Offers:

- Associate degrees
- Workforce certifications
- Continuing education
- Technical training
- Transfer pathways to four-year universities

Veteran resource centers are available to assist eligible students with VA education benefits.

The University of Texas at Arlington (UTA)

UTA provides undergraduate, graduate, and professional degree programs across numerous academic disciplines.

Veteran students have access to:

- Veteran services
 - Academic advising
 - Disability accommodations
 - Student organizations
 - Career development resources
-

Texas Wesleyan University

Texas Wesleyan offers undergraduate and graduate degree programs while participating in VA education benefit programs for eligible students.

Texas Christian University (TCU)

TCU welcomes veterans and military-connected students through a variety of academic and student support services.

Veterans should contact the school's Veterans Affairs Certifying Official regarding available education benefits.

Professional Certifications

Many industries value professional certifications as much as traditional degrees.

Veterans may use education benefits for approved certification programs in fields such as:

- Cybersecurity
- Project Management
- Information Technology
- Healthcare
- Construction
- Manufacturing
- Accounting
- Aviation
- Logistics
- Commercial Driving

Professional certifications can improve employment opportunities and earning potential.

Apprenticeships and On-the-Job Training

Some education benefits may also be used while participating in approved apprenticeship or on-the-job training programs.

These programs allow veterans to:

- Earn income while learning
- Develop specialized skills
- Gain industry experience
- Work toward long-term careers

Many employers throughout Texas participate in approved apprenticeship programs.

Scholarships for Veterans

In addition to federal and state benefits, veterans may qualify for scholarships offered by:

- Colleges and universities
- Private foundations
- Veteran service organizations
- Community organizations
- Professional associations

Scholarship opportunities change frequently. Veterans should contact each institution's financial aid office for current information.

Returning to School Successfully

Returning to the classroom after military service can be challenging.

Helpful suggestions include:

- Meet with a school veteran advisor.
- Apply for financial aid early.
- Register with disability services if accommodations are needed.
- Join campus veteran organizations.
- Develop a study schedule.
- Ask for help when needed.
- Use tutoring resources.
- Stay connected with instructors.

Many campuses have Veteran Resource Centers specifically designed to support military-connected students.

Veteran Tip

Do not assume a four-year degree is your only option. Skilled trades, apprenticeships, certifications, and technical education often lead to rewarding careers with strong earning potential.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I use both federal and Texas education benefits?

In some situations, yes. The way benefits work together depends on the specific programs and your eligibility. Speak with your school's VA Certifying Official before enrolling.

What if I left the military many years ago?

You may still qualify for education benefits depending on your military service and the specific program.

Can my spouse or children use my benefits?

Some education benefits may be transferable if eligibility requirements are met. Transfer rules vary by program.

Quick Reference

Major Education Resources

U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs

- GI Bill
- VR&E
- Education payments
- Benefit verification

Texas Veterans Commission

- Education guidance
- State veteran education resources

Hazlewood Act

- Tuition exemption at eligible Texas public institutions

Tarrant County College

- Veteran Resource Center
- Workforce training

- Associate degrees
- Transfer programs

University of Texas at Arlington

- Veteran services
- Undergraduate and graduate education

Education opens doors to new careers, greater financial stability, and lifelong opportunities. The benefits earned through military service represent an investment in your future. Veterans are encouraged to fully explore every education and training opportunity available to them and their families.

Chapter 7

Financial Assistance & Emergency Support

When Life Takes an Unexpected Turn

Financial hardships can happen to anyone. Medical emergencies, job loss, family crises, natural disasters, or unexpected expenses can quickly place veterans and their families under financial stress.

Fortunately, many federal, state, county, and nonprofit organizations provide temporary financial assistance to eligible veterans throughout Tarrant County.

Seeking assistance early often provides more options than waiting until a crisis becomes overwhelming.

Emergency Financial Assistance

Emergency assistance programs are designed to help veterans maintain stability while working toward long-term financial independence.

Depending on eligibility and funding availability, assistance may include:

- Rent or mortgage assistance
- Utility payments
- Emergency food assistance
- Temporary lodging
- Transportation assistance
- Clothing assistance
- Medical expense assistance
- Case management
- Financial counseling

Programs differ in eligibility requirements, available funding, and documentation needed.

Texas Veterans Commission Fund for Veterans' Assistance

The Texas Veterans Commission (TVC) administers the Fund for Veterans' Assistance, which awards grants to nonprofit organizations and local governments serving veterans and their families throughout Texas.

Programs funded through these grants may provide:

- Housing assistance
- Employment services
- Mental health counseling
- Peer support
- Transportation
- Financial assistance
- Legal services
- Family support
- Benefits navigation

Veterans do not apply directly to the grant program. Instead, they receive services through participating local organizations.

Catholic Charities Fort Worth

Catholic Charities Fort Worth assists eligible veterans and families through a variety of community programs.

Services may include:

- Emergency financial assistance
- Rent assistance
- Utility assistance
- Financial coaching
- Case management
- Food assistance
- Community referrals

Funding availability varies throughout the year.

The Salvation Army

The Salvation Army provides emergency assistance for individuals and families experiencing financial hardship.

Programs may include:

- Emergency shelter
- Utility assistance
- Food assistance
- Clothing assistance
- Disaster relief
- Case management
- Holiday assistance

Eligibility and available assistance vary by location.

Society of St. Vincent de Paul

Many local St. Vincent de Paul conferences assist individuals and families experiencing temporary financial hardship.

Services may include:

- Utility assistance
- Rent assistance
- Food assistance
- Clothing
- Household essentials
- Referrals to additional community resources

Assistance is generally based on available funding and local program guidelines.

Budgeting for Long-Term Success

Financial assistance is intended to provide temporary relief.

Creating a realistic monthly budget can help reduce future financial stress.

Consider including:

- Housing
- Utilities
- Transportation
- Insurance
- Food
- Medical expenses
- Savings
- Emergency fund
- Debt payments

Even small monthly savings can provide protection against future emergencies.

Protect Yourself from Scams

Unfortunately, veterans are sometimes targeted by scammers.

Be cautious if someone:

- Promises guaranteed VA benefits.
- Requests payment to file a disability claim.
- Asks for your VA login credentials.
- Pressures you to sign documents immediately.

- Offers unrealistic investment opportunities.
- Requests payment by gift cards or cryptocurrency.

Remember:

Accredited DAV Service Officers never charge veterans for filing VA disability claims.

If something seems suspicious, ask questions before providing personal information or making payments.

Identity Theft Protection

Protect important personal information such as:

- Social Security number
- VA identification number
- Banking information
- VA.gov login credentials
- Military discharge documents

Store important documents in a secure location and regularly monitor your financial accounts for unauthorized activity.

Financial Counseling

Many nonprofit organizations provide free financial education for veterans.

Topics may include:

- Budget creation
- Credit improvement
- Debt reduction
- Saving strategies
- Homeownership preparation
- Retirement planning

Financial education helps veterans build lasting financial security beyond emergency assistance.

Disaster Assistance

Veterans affected by natural disasters such as floods, tornadoes, severe storms, or wildfires may qualify for emergency assistance from local, state, or federal agencies.

Assistance may include:

- Temporary housing
- Food
- Clothing
- Home repairs
- Disaster recovery grants
- Crisis counseling

During declared disasters, monitor local emergency management agencies for updated information.

Frequently Asked Questions

Should I wait until my utilities are disconnected before asking for help?

No. Contact assistance programs as soon as you receive a past-due notice. Early action often increases the likelihood of receiving assistance.

Can I receive help more than once?

Some programs allow repeat assistance under certain circumstances, while others have limits. Each organization establishes its own eligibility requirements.

Will receiving assistance affect my VA disability compensation?

Emergency financial assistance from community organizations generally does not affect VA disability compensation, but veterans should consult the appropriate agency regarding individual situations.

Veteran Tip

If you need assistance from more than one organization, keep copies of your identification, DD Form 214, lease agreement, utility bills, and income documentation together in a folder. Having your documents organized can significantly speed up the application process.

Important Documents to Bring

When applying for financial assistance, you may be asked to provide:

- Government-issued photo ID
- DD Form 214
- Social Security card
- Proof of residency
- Lease or mortgage statement
- Utility bills
- Proof of income
- Bank statements
- VA award letter, if applicable
- Eviction or disconnect notices, if applicable

Documentation requirements vary by organization.

Quick Reference

Organizations That May Provide Financial Assistance

Texas Veterans Commission Fund for Veterans' Assistance

- Veteran support through funded local organizations
- Housing assistance
- Employment services
- Mental health support
- Transportation

Catholic Charities Fort Worth

- Emergency financial assistance
- Rent assistance
- Utility assistance
- Case management

The Salvation Army

- Food assistance
- Utility assistance
- Emergency shelter
- Disaster services

Society of St. Vincent de Paul

- Rent assistance
- Utility assistance
- Food assistance
- Household support

Financial challenges do not define your future. Assistance is available, and asking for help early can prevent a temporary setback from becoming a long-term crisis.

Chapter 8

Food Assistance & Nutrition Resources

No Veteran Should Go Hungry

Access to nutritious food is essential for good health, recovery, and overall well-being. Veterans experiencing financial hardship, unemployment, illness, or unexpected life events should know that help is available throughout Tarrant County.

Food assistance programs exist to provide temporary support while veterans work toward long-term financial stability.

Many organizations also offer additional services such as financial counseling, housing referrals, employment assistance, and case management.

Tarrant Area Food Bank

The Tarrant Area Food Bank partners with hundreds of food pantries, churches, schools, and nonprofit organizations throughout Tarrant County.

Available services may include:

- Emergency food boxes
- Fresh produce
- Dairy products
- Meat and protein items
- Mobile food distributions
- Senior nutrition programs
- SNAP application assistance

Food distributions vary by location and schedule.

Mission Arlington

Mission Arlington has served North Texas families for decades by providing emergency assistance and community support.

Programs may include:

- Groceries
- Clothing
- Household items
- School supplies
- Holiday assistance
- Medical equipment
- Financial assistance referrals

Many services are provided at no cost to eligible individuals.

The Salvation Army

The Salvation Army operates several assistance programs throughout Tarrant County.

Food-related services may include:

- Emergency food boxes
- Community meals
- Holiday meals
- Grocery assistance
- Family support services

Additional programs may also assist with housing, utilities, and emergency financial needs.

Meals on Wheels

Eligible senior veterans and veterans with disabilities may qualify for home-delivered meals through Meals on Wheels.

Services often include:

- Nutritious daily meals
- Wellness checks
- Friendly visits
- Nutrition education
- Referrals to additional community services

Eligibility varies by location and program guidelines.

Community Food Pantries

Many churches and nonprofit organizations throughout Tarrant County operate local food pantries.

These pantries may provide:

- Nonperishable groceries
- Fresh produce
- Frozen foods
- Infant supplies
- Personal hygiene items

Veterans are encouraged to contact pantries in advance to confirm distribution schedules and eligibility requirements.

Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP)

Veterans with limited income may qualify for SNAP benefits, formerly known as food stamps.

SNAP benefits can be used to purchase eligible food items at participating grocery stores and retailers.

Applications are administered by the Texas Health and Human Services Commission.

Eligibility depends on household income, household size, and other factors established by state and federal law.

Nutrition and Health

Good nutrition plays an important role in managing many chronic health conditions.

Healthy eating may help improve:

- Heart health
- Diabetes management
- Blood pressure
- Weight management
- Bone health
- Energy levels
- Recovery after illness or surgery

Veterans enrolled in VA health care may also have access to nutrition counseling through registered dietitians.

Holiday Assistance

Many community organizations provide seasonal assistance during Thanksgiving and Christmas.

Programs may include:

- Holiday meals
- Food baskets
- Children's gifts
- Winter clothing
- Household essentials

Registration is often required in advance.

Frequently Asked Questions

I have a job but still struggle to buy groceries. Can I ask for help?

Yes. Many food assistance programs serve working families experiencing temporary financial hardship.

Will using a food pantry affect my VA benefits?

Food assistance from community organizations generally does not affect VA disability compensation or VA health care benefits.

Can my family receive assistance too?

Many programs serve the entire household, including spouses and dependent children.

Veteran Tip

Do not wait until your pantry is empty before seeking assistance. Food programs are designed to help veterans through difficult times while protecting their health and financial stability.

Important Documents to Bring

Some organizations may request:

- Government-issued photo ID
- Proof of address
- Proof of income
- Household information
- Identification for family members

Many emergency food programs have minimal documentation requirements.

Quick Reference

Food Resources in Tarrant County

Tarrant Area Food Bank

- Emergency food
- Mobile distributions
- SNAP assistance
- Community pantry network

Mission Arlington

- Groceries
- Clothing
- Household assistance
- Community support

The Salvation Army

- Food boxes
- Community meals
- Holiday assistance
- Family services

Meals on Wheels

- Home-delivered meals
- Wellness checks

- Senior nutrition

No veteran should have to choose between purchasing food, paying rent, or buying medication. If you are struggling to provide meals for yourself or your family, reach out to one of the organizations listed in this chapter. Assistance is available, and asking for help is the first step toward regaining stability.

Chapter 9

Transportation Services

Getting to the Care and Services You Need

Reliable transportation should never prevent a veteran from receiving medical care, attending a benefits appointment, seeking employment, or participating in community programs.

Numerous transportation resources are available throughout Tarrant County to help eligible veterans travel to VA medical appointments and other essential services.

If transportation has become a barrier, ask for help before missing an appointment.

DAV Transportation Network

The Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Transportation Network helps eligible veterans travel to scheduled VA medical appointments.

Volunteer drivers and DAV partners assist thousands of veterans each year by providing transportation to VA health care facilities.

Transportation availability varies depending on volunteer schedules, appointment times, and service areas.

Veterans should schedule transportation as early as possible.

VA Beneficiary Travel Program

Eligible veterans may qualify for reimbursement of travel expenses when traveling to approved VA medical appointments.

Depending on eligibility, reimbursement may include:

- Mileage reimbursement
- Special mode transportation when medically necessary
- Transportation for approved medical appointments

Eligibility is based on VA regulations and individual circumstances.

Veterans should contact the VA before traveling if they have questions about reimbursement.

Trinity Metro

Trinity Metro provides public transportation throughout Fort Worth and surrounding communities.

Services include:

- Fixed-route bus service
- TEXRail
- Trinity Railway Express (TRE) connections
- ZIPZONE on-demand service in participating areas
- Mobility services for eligible riders

Reduced fares may be available for qualifying individuals.

Veterans should visit Trinity Metro or call customer service for current routes, schedules, and fare information.

Mobility Services

Veterans with disabilities who cannot use traditional public transportation may qualify for specialized transportation services.

Depending on eligibility, services may include:

- Door-to-door transportation
- Wheelchair-accessible vehicles
- Scheduled medical transportation
- ADA paratransit services

Advance reservations are generally required.

Non-Emergency Medical Transportation

Some veterans may qualify for transportation through:

- Local nonprofit organizations
- County programs
- Medical providers
- Health insurance plans
- Community volunteer programs

Availability varies throughout Tarrant County.

Transportation for Senior Veterans

Senior veterans may have access to transportation programs that assist with:

- Medical appointments
- Grocery shopping
- Pharmacy visits
- Senior centers
- Community activities

Many senior service organizations coordinate transportation with other support services.

Planning Your Trip

Before traveling to an appointment:

- Confirm the appointment date and time.
- Verify the clinic address.
- Arrive early.
- Bring your photo identification.
- Bring your Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC), if applicable.
- Bring a current medication list.
- Carry emergency contact information.

If transportation has been arranged through a volunteer program, notify the organization immediately if your appointment changes or is cancelled.

Transportation Safety

When traveling:

- Keep important medical information with you.
 - Carry necessary medications.
 - Bring water during hot weather.
 - Wear your seatbelt.
 - Allow extra travel time for traffic or weather delays.
 - Keep your cell phone charged.
-

Frequently Asked Questions

I do not own a vehicle. Can I still receive VA medical care?

Yes. Transportation assistance may be available through DAV, the VA, public transportation providers, or local community organizations depending on your eligibility.

Do I need to schedule transportation in advance?

Yes. Most transportation providers require advance notice, especially volunteer driver programs.

Can someone travel with me?

Some transportation programs allow caregivers or attendants when medically necessary. Ask the transportation provider when scheduling your ride.

Veteran Tip

Schedule transportation as soon as your medical appointment is confirmed. Volunteer transportation services are in high demand, and early scheduling provides the best opportunity to secure a ride.

Important Documents to Bring

- Government-issued photo ID
 - Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC), if available
 - Appointment information
 - Medication list
 - Emergency contact information
 - Insurance information, if applicable
-

Quick Reference

Transportation Resources

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Transportation Network

- Transportation to VA medical appointments
- Volunteer drivers
- Veteran-focused assistance

VA Beneficiary Travel Program

- Mileage reimbursement for eligible veterans
- Travel assistance for qualifying medical appointments

Trinity Metro

- Bus service
- TEXRail

- ZIPZONE
- Mobility services

Reliable transportation is an important part of maintaining your health and independence. If transportation is preventing you from receiving medical care or accessing veterans services, contact one of the organizations listed in this chapter as early as possible.

Chapter 10

Women Veterans

Honoring the Service of Women Veterans

Women have proudly served in every branch of the United States Armed Forces for generations. Today, women veterans represent one of the fastest growing veteran populations in America.

Like all veterans, women have earned access to VA health care, disability compensation, education benefits, employment assistance, home loan programs, and many other federal and state benefits.

The Department of Veterans Affairs has expanded services to better meet the unique health care needs of women veterans while providing comprehensive medical, mental health, maternity, and preventive care.

VA Women's Health Services

Eligible women veterans may receive comprehensive health care through the VA North Texas Health Care System.

Available services may include:

- Primary care
- Annual wellness examinations
- Preventive screenings
- Gynecological care

- Breast cancer screening
- Cervical cancer screening
- Family planning
- Menopause care
- Maternity care coordination
- Mental health services
- Nutrition counseling
- Pharmacy services
- Telehealth appointments

Women veterans are encouraged to establish care with a VA primary care provider as early as possible.

Women Veterans Program Manager

Every VA health care system has a Women Veterans Program Manager who helps coordinate services and connect women veterans with available resources.

The Program Manager can assist with:

- Enrollment questions
- Health care navigation
- Specialty referrals
- Maternity care coordination
- Community resources
- Women-specific health services

If you are unsure where to begin, ask to speak with the Women Veterans Program Manager.

Maternity Care

Eligible veterans who become pregnant may qualify for maternity care coordinated through the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Depending on eligibility, maternity benefits may include:

- Prenatal care
- Obstetric services

- Hospital delivery
- Postpartum care
- Newborn care coordination
- Breastfeeding support

Maternity care is generally provided through community health care providers coordinated by the VA.

Military Sexual Trauma (MST)

Military Sexual Trauma refers to sexual assault or repeated, threatening sexual harassment experienced during military service.

Veterans affected by MST may receive confidential treatment through the VA regardless of gender.

Available services may include:

- Individual counseling
- Group counseling
- Trauma-informed care
- Psychiatric services
- Medication management
- Referrals to additional resources

Many veterans qualify for MST-related care even if they are not service connected for the condition.

Mental Health Support

Women veterans may experience unique challenges during and after military service.

The VA offers treatment for:

- PTSD
- Depression
- Anxiety
- Grief
- Military transition

- Relationship concerns
- Substance use disorders
- Stress management

Services are available both in person and through telehealth.

Preventive Health

Preventive care is an important part of maintaining long-term health.

Women veterans should discuss recommended screenings with their health care provider, including:

- Blood pressure screening
- Cholesterol screening
- Diabetes screening
- Breast cancer screening
- Cervical cancer screening
- Bone health evaluation
- Colon cancer screening
- Vaccinations

Early detection often improves treatment outcomes.

Family Caregiver Support

Many women veterans balance careers, military service, education, and family responsibilities.

VA and community organizations offer support through:

- Caregiver education
- Parenting resources
- Mental health counseling
- Family support services
- Community referrals

Additional caregiver resources are discussed in Chapter 11.

Employment and Education

Women veterans have access to the same education and employment benefits available to all eligible veterans, including:

- GI Bill® education benefits
- Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E)
- Texas Hazlewood Act
- Career counseling
- Resume assistance
- Professional certifications
- Small business resources

Many organizations also provide networking opportunities specifically for women veterans.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do women veterans receive the same VA benefits as men?

Yes. Eligibility is based on military service and applicable program requirements, not gender.

Can I receive maternity care through the VA?

Eligible veterans may qualify for VA-coordinated maternity care. Speak with your VA provider or Women Veterans Program Manager for details.

I served many years ago. Can I still enroll in VA health care?

Yes. Many women veterans who have never used VA services may still qualify. Contact the VA or DAV Chapter 246 for enrollment assistance.

Veteran Tip

Many women veterans do not identify themselves as veterans when seeking health care or community services. Always let providers know about your military service, as additional benefits and resources may be available.

Important Documents to Bring

When enrolling in VA health care or applying for benefits, you may be asked to provide:

- DD Form 214
 - Government-issued photo ID
 - Social Security number
 - Health insurance information, if applicable
 - Previous VA correspondence
 - Medical records related to your claim or treatment
-

Quick Reference

Women's Veteran Resources

VA North Texas Health Care System

- Women's primary care
- Preventive health
- Maternity care coordination
- Mental health
- Pharmacy
- Telehealth

Women Veterans Program Manager

- Enrollment assistance
- Care coordination
- Resource referrals
- Women-specific health services

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246

- Free VA disability claims assistance
- Benefits guidance
- Referrals to local veteran resources

Women have served our nation with courage, dedication, and distinction. Every woman veteran deserves access to the benefits, health care, and support earned through military service. Whether you served during wartime or peacetime, your service matters, and help is available throughout Tarrant County and the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Chapter 11

Family Members, Caregivers & Survivor Support

Supporting Those Who Serve Beside Our Veterans

Military service affects more than the individual who wears the uniform. Spouses, children, parents, caregivers, and survivors often share in the challenges that come with military service, disability, illness, recovery, and transition to civilian life.

The Department of Veterans Affairs, the State of Texas, and community organizations throughout Tarrant County offer programs designed to support those who care for our nation's veterans.

Whether you are caring for an aging parent, a wounded veteran, or assisting a loved one through recovery, you are not alone.

VA Caregiver Support Program

The VA Caregiver Support Program helps family members and caregivers who provide ongoing care to eligible veterans.

Available services may include:

- Caregiver education
- Skills training
- Individual support
- Care coordination

- Resource referrals
- Peer support
- Caregiver coaching
- Wellness resources

The program is designed to help caregivers feel prepared, supported, and connected.

Program of Comprehensive Assistance for Family Caregivers (PCAFC)

Eligible caregivers may qualify for additional support through the Program of Comprehensive Assistance for Family Caregivers.

Depending on eligibility, benefits may include:

- Caregiver education and training
- Ongoing support
- Care planning
- Health insurance options for qualifying caregivers
- Financial stipend for eligible participants
- Respite care
- Mental health services

Eligibility requirements are determined by the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Program of General Caregiver Support Services (PGCSS)

Caregivers who do not qualify for PCAFC may still receive assistance through the Program of General Caregiver Support Services.

Services may include:

- Educational workshops
- Support groups
- Caregiver coaching

- Resource referrals
- Information about available community programs

Many caregivers qualify for valuable support even if they are not eligible for financial assistance.

Respite Care

Providing full-time care can be physically and emotionally demanding.

Respite care allows caregivers to take a temporary break while ensuring the veteran continues receiving appropriate care.

Respite services may be provided:

- At home
- Through adult day health programs
- At VA facilities
- Through approved community providers

Availability depends on eligibility and local resources.

Home-Based Primary Care

Some veterans with serious illnesses or limited mobility may qualify for Home-Based Primary Care.

This program brings medical care directly to eligible veterans in their homes.

Services may include:

- Physician visits
- Nursing care
- Medication management
- Social work
- Nutrition services
- Rehabilitation support

Home-Based Primary Care helps reduce hospital visits while improving quality of life.

Adult Day Health Care

Adult Day Health Care programs provide supervised daytime care for eligible veterans.

Programs may include:

- Health monitoring
- Therapy services
- Meals
- Recreational activities
- Social interaction
- Caregiver relief

These programs allow caregivers to continue working or attend to personal responsibilities while knowing their loved one is receiving appropriate care.

Support for Military and Veteran Families

Military families often face challenges related to:

- Frequent relocations
- Employment changes
- Financial stress
- Medical care
- Childcare
- Mental health
- Caregiving responsibilities

Community organizations throughout Tarrant County offer counseling, family support programs, financial education, and referrals to additional services.

Survivor Benefits

Family members of deceased veterans may qualify for benefits through the Department of Veterans Affairs.

Depending on eligibility, survivor benefits may include:

- Dependency and Indemnity Compensation (DIC)
- Survivor pension
- Burial benefits
- Education benefits
- Home loan assistance
- Health care programs
- Memorial benefits

Eligibility varies depending on military service and individual circumstances.

DAV Chapter 246 can assist eligible survivors in understanding available benefits and completing the application process.

Bereavement Counseling

Losing a loved one can be one of life's most difficult experiences.

Bereavement counseling may be available through:

- VA Vet Centers
- Community counseling providers
- Faith-based organizations
- Hospice programs
- Licensed mental health professionals

Grief affects everyone differently, and seeking support is an important part of the healing process.

Planning Ahead

Families are encouraged to organize important documents before they are needed.

Consider keeping copies of:

- DD Form 214
- VA award letters
- Marriage certificate

- Birth certificates
- Insurance policies
- Powers of attorney
- Advance directives
- Financial records
- Emergency contact information

Keeping these documents together can make future benefit applications much easier.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can a family member contact DAV on behalf of a veteran?

Yes. Family members and caregivers may contact DAV Chapter 246 to learn about available resources and schedule appointments.

Are caregiver services only for elderly veterans?

No. Caregiver programs support veterans of all ages who meet eligibility requirements.

Can surviving spouses receive VA benefits?

Some surviving spouses and dependents may qualify for VA survivor benefits depending on the veteran's military service and other eligibility requirements.

Veteran Tip

Caregivers often focus entirely on the veteran and forget to care for themselves. Taking time to rest, seek support, and ask for assistance helps you continue providing the best possible care for your loved one.

Important Documents to Bring

When applying for caregiver or survivor benefits, you may be asked to provide:

- DD Form 214
 - Government-issued photo ID
 - Marriage certificate
 - Birth certificates
 - VA decision letters
 - Medical documentation
 - Death certificate, if applicable
 - Financial information required for specific benefit programs
-

Quick Reference

Caregiver & Family Resources

VA Caregiver Support Program

- Caregiver education
- Care planning
- Resource referrals
- Support services

Program of Comprehensive Assistance for Family Caregivers

- Financial stipend for eligible caregivers
- Training
- Health insurance options
- Ongoing support

Program of General Caregiver Support Services

- Education
- Coaching
- Support groups
- Community resources

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246

- Survivor benefits guidance
- Dependency claims assistance
- VA benefits counseling
- Community referrals

The care and support provided by family members and caregivers play an essential role in the well-being of our veterans. Their dedication deserves recognition, support, and access to the resources available through the Department of Veterans Affairs and the Tarrant County community.

Chapter 12

Senior Veterans, Aging Services & Long-Term Care

Honoring Those Who Served Before Us

America's senior veterans represent generations of courage, sacrifice, and service. As veterans age, their needs often change. Access to quality health care, long-term care, caregiver support, financial assistance, and independent living resources becomes increasingly important.

The Department of Veterans Affairs, the State of Texas, and community organizations throughout Tarrant County provide programs that help older veterans maintain their independence, dignity, and quality of life.

Whether you wish to remain in your own home, need additional daily assistance, or require skilled nursing care, resources are available to help.

Geriatric Primary Care

The VA offers specialized health care designed for older veterans.

Services may include:

- Comprehensive health evaluations
- Chronic disease management
- Medication management
- Fall prevention
- Memory assessments

- Nutrition counseling
- Preventive care
- Care coordination

These services help veterans maintain their health while supporting independent living whenever possible.

Home-Based Primary Care

Some veterans with chronic illnesses or limited mobility may qualify for Home-Based Primary Care.

This interdisciplinary program delivers medical care in the veteran's home and may include:

- Physician services
- Nursing care
- Social work
- Pharmacy review
- Nutrition counseling
- Rehabilitation planning

The goal is to improve quality of life while reducing unnecessary hospital visits.

Homemaker and Home Health Aide Services

Eligible veterans may receive assistance with everyday activities through Homemaker and Home Health Aide programs.

Services may include:

- Personal hygiene assistance
- Bathing
- Dressing
- Meal preparation
- Light housekeeping
- Mobility assistance

- Medication reminders

These services are intended to help veterans remain safely in their homes for as long as possible.

Adult Day Health Care

Adult Day Health Care programs provide supervised daytime care for veterans who need assistance while allowing caregivers time to work or attend to personal responsibilities.

Programs may include:

- Nursing care
- Therapy services
- Meals
- Recreational activities
- Health monitoring
- Social interaction

Participation may improve quality of life while providing valuable caregiver support.

Community Living Centers

VA Community Living Centers provide skilled nursing care and rehabilitation services for eligible veterans requiring a higher level of medical care.

Services may include:

- Short-term rehabilitation
- Skilled nursing care
- Hospice services
- Dementia care
- Respite care
- Long-term residential care

Admission is based on medical need and VA eligibility requirements.

Texas State Veterans Homes

The Texas Veterans Land Board operates State Veterans Homes that provide long-term nursing care for eligible veterans, spouses, and in some cases surviving spouses.

Residents may receive:

- Skilled nursing care
- Rehabilitation
- Memory care
- Social activities
- Dietary services
- Medical oversight

Veterans interested in residency should apply well in advance, as availability varies by location.

Hospice and Palliative Care

Veterans facing serious or life-limiting illnesses may qualify for hospice or palliative care.

Hospice focuses on comfort and quality of life, while palliative care helps manage symptoms during serious illness.

Services may include:

- Pain management
- Nursing care
- Emotional support
- Spiritual care
- Family counseling
- Bereavement support

These services may be provided at home, in a VA facility, or through approved community providers.

Aid and Attendance Benefit

Some wartime veterans and surviving spouses may qualify for the VA Aid and Attendance benefit.

This benefit may provide additional monthly financial assistance for individuals who require help with daily living activities such as:

- Bathing
- Dressing
- Eating
- Mobility
- Medication management

Eligibility is based on medical and financial requirements established by the VA.

DAV Chapter 246 can assist veterans and surviving spouses in determining whether they may qualify.

Fall Prevention

Falls are a leading cause of injury among older adults.

Veterans can reduce fall risks by:

- Removing tripping hazards
- Installing grab bars
- Improving lighting
- Wearing supportive footwear
- Exercising regularly
- Reviewing medications with their health care provider
- Scheduling annual vision and hearing exams

Discuss fall prevention with your VA provider if you have concerns about balance or mobility.

Advance Care Planning

Every veteran should consider documenting future medical wishes before they become necessary.

Important planning documents may include:

- Advance Directive
- Medical Power of Attorney
- Durable Power of Attorney
- Living Will
- Emergency Contact List

Discuss these documents with family members and keep copies in an accessible location.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I receive long-term care through the VA?

Some eligible veterans may qualify for long-term care services through the VA or approved community providers depending on medical need and eligibility.

Can I remain in my own home instead of moving into a nursing facility?

Many veterans qualify for home-based services that support independent living for as long as it is safe and medically appropriate.

Can my spouse receive care in a Texas State Veterans Home?

Certain spouses and surviving spouses may qualify under Texas Veterans Land Board eligibility requirements.

Veteran Tip

Do not wait until a medical emergency to learn about long-term care options. Planning ahead gives you and your family more choices and reduces stress during difficult times.

Important Documents to Bring

When applying for senior services or long-term care, you may be asked to provide:

- DD Form 214
 - Government-issued photo ID
 - VA award letters
 - Medical records
 - Insurance information
 - Current medication list
 - Financial information for income-based programs
 - Advance directive documents, if available
-

Quick Reference

Senior Veteran Resources

VA North Texas Health Care System

- Geriatric care
- Home-Based Primary Care
- Community Living Centers
- Hospice and palliative care

Texas Veterans Land Board

- State Veterans Homes
- Long-term nursing care
- Memory care
- Rehabilitation services

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246

- Benefits counseling
- Aid and Attendance guidance
- Survivor benefits assistance
- Referrals to local senior resources

Growing older should never mean facing life's challenges alone. Veterans have earned access to health care, long-term care, financial assistance, and supportive services that promote independence and dignity. Veterans and their families are encouraged to explore these resources early and plan for the future with confidence.

Chapter 13

Legal Services & Veterans Rights

Understanding Your Legal Rights

Legal issues can affect every aspect of a veteran's life, including employment, housing, finances, family relationships, and access to benefits. Many veterans face legal challenges after military service, but free or low-cost legal assistance is available throughout Tarrant County.

Veterans should seek qualified legal advice as early as possible. Addressing legal issues promptly often prevents more serious problems in the future.

Many organizations provide legal assistance specifically for veterans and military families.

Texas Lawyers for Texas Veterans

Texas Lawyers for Texas Veterans is a statewide legal program that provides free civil legal clinics for eligible veterans.

Volunteer attorneys may assist with matters such as:

- VA benefits
- Family law
- Consumer issues
- Landlord and tenant disputes
- Wills
- Estate planning
- Expunctions and nondisclosures
- Employment issues

Services vary depending on clinic location and volunteer availability.

Legal Aid of NorthWest Texas

Legal Aid of NorthWest Texas provides free civil legal assistance to eligible low-income individuals, including many veterans.

Services may include:

- Housing issues
- Consumer protection
- Family law
- Public benefits
- Employment matters
- Protective orders
- Elder law

Eligibility is based on program guidelines and available resources.

Veterans Treatment Courts

Veterans Treatment Courts recognize that some justice-involved veterans may be dealing with service-related conditions such as PTSD, traumatic brain injury, or substance use disorders.

These specialized courts combine accountability with treatment and community support.

Programs often include:

- Judicial supervision
- Counseling
- Substance use treatment
- Veteran mentors
- Case management
- Community resources

Participation requirements are determined by the local court.

Estate Planning

Every veteran should have a basic estate plan.

Important documents include:

- Last Will and Testament
- Medical Power of Attorney
- Durable Power of Attorney
- Advance Directive
- HIPAA Authorization
- Beneficiary Designations

Estate planning helps ensure that your wishes are honored and can reduce stress for your loved ones.

Consumer Protection

Veterans are sometimes targeted by scams involving:

- Fake VA benefits
- Identity theft
- Investment fraud
- Home repair scams
- Charity fraud
- Telephone scams
- Online scams
- Impersonation of government agencies

Never provide personal information unless you have confirmed the identity of the organization requesting it.

If you are uncertain, contact DAV Chapter 246 or the appropriate government agency before responding.

Identity Theft

Protect important personal information, including:

- Social Security number
- VA.gov account credentials
- Banking information
- Military records
- Driver license

- Veteran Health Identification Card

If you believe your identity has been compromised:

- Contact your financial institutions.
 - Monitor your credit reports.
 - Report fraud to the appropriate authorities.
 - Change passwords immediately.
-

Housing Rights

Veterans who rent or own homes have legal rights under federal and Texas law.

Legal assistance may be available for:

- Eviction proceedings
- Housing discrimination
- Mortgage issues
- Landlord disputes
- Property damage claims

Do not ignore court notices or legal documents.

Seek assistance as soon as possible.

Employment Rights

Veterans are protected by various federal and state employment laws.

These protections may involve:

- Military leave
- Reemployment rights
- Workplace discrimination
- Disability accommodations
- Equal employment opportunities

Questions regarding employment rights should be discussed with the appropriate agency or a qualified attorney.

Family Law

Veterans may need legal assistance with:

- Divorce
- Child custody
- Child support
- Adoption
- Guardianship
- Protective orders

Family law issues can affect VA benefits and financial planning, making experienced legal guidance especially important.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can DAV provide legal representation?

DAV provides assistance with VA benefits and claims. For legal matters outside the VA claims process, veterans should work with qualified attorneys or legal aid organizations.

Can I receive free legal help?

Many veterans qualify for free or reduced-cost legal services depending on income, military service, and the type of legal issue involved.

Should I wait until my court date to ask for help?

No. Contact a legal services provider as soon as you receive legal paperwork or believe a legal issue is developing.

Veteran Tip

Keep copies of important legal documents in a secure location and let a trusted family member know where they are stored. Being organized can save valuable time during emergencies.

Important Documents to Bring

When meeting with a legal services provider, bring:

- Government-issued photo ID
 - DD Form 214
 - Court documents
 - Contracts
 - Correspondence
 - VA decision letters, if applicable
 - Financial records related to your legal issue
 - Any other documents supporting your case
-

Quick Reference

Legal Resources

Texas Lawyers for Texas Veterans

- Veterans legal clinics
- Estate planning
- Consumer law
- Family law
- VA-related legal guidance

Legal Aid of NorthWest Texas

- Civil legal assistance
- Housing
- Employment
- Public benefits
- Family law

Veterans Treatment Courts

- Treatment-focused court programs
- Veteran mentors
- Rehabilitation resources

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246

- VA benefits guidance
- Disability claims assistance
- Appeals assistance
- Referrals to community legal resources

Understanding your legal rights is an important part of protecting your future. Whether you need help with benefits, housing, employment, family matters, or consumer protection, resources are available to help you make informed decisions and move forward with confidence.

Chapter 14

Texas Veterans Benefits

Benefits Beyond the Department of Veterans Affairs

In addition to federal VA benefits, the State of Texas offers one of the nation's most comprehensive collections of benefits for veterans and their families.

These programs recognize the sacrifices made by veterans and provide assistance with education, housing, employment, recreation, health care, and financial security.

Eligibility varies depending on military service, disability rating, residency, and other program requirements.

Veterans are encouraged to contact the Texas Veterans Commission or DAV Chapter 246 to determine which state benefits may apply to their individual circumstances.

Texas Veterans Commission

The Texas Veterans Commission (TVC) serves as the state's primary agency for veterans services.

The Commission assists veterans and their families with:

- Benefits assistance
- Employment services
- Education guidance
- Entrepreneur resources
- Mental health programs
- Grants for community organizations
- Veteran outreach
- Claims representation

Many TVC services are provided at no cost.

Property Tax Exemptions

Texas offers property tax exemptions for qualifying disabled veterans and, in some situations, surviving spouses.

Depending on eligibility, exemptions may reduce or eliminate property taxes on a veteran's primary residence.

Eligibility depends upon:

- VA disability rating
- Ownership of the residence
- Texas residency
- Applicable state law

Veterans should contact their local county appraisal district for current requirements and application procedures.

Disabled Veteran License Plates

Eligible veterans may qualify for Disabled Veteran license plates issued by the Texas Department of Motor Vehicles.

Depending on eligibility, these plates may provide:

- Official Disabled Veteran registration
- Certain parking privileges where authorized by law
- Recognition of military service

Applicants must meet current state eligibility requirements.

Texas Veterans Land Board

The Texas Veterans Land Board (VLB) administers several programs designed to help veterans and military families.

Programs include:

- Veterans Land Loans
- Veterans Housing Assistance
- Home Improvement Loans
- Texas State Veterans Homes
- Texas State Veterans Cemeteries

The Veterans Land Board has served Texas veterans since 1946.

Veterans Housing Assistance Program

Eligible veterans may qualify for home loans through the Texas Veterans Land Board.

Benefits may include:

- Competitive interest rates
- Low or no down payment options for qualifying borrowers
- Assistance purchasing a primary residence
- Additional financing opportunities

Loan approval depends upon credit qualifications and program requirements.

Veterans Land Loans

Texas veterans interested in purchasing rural land may qualify for Veterans Land Loans through the Veterans Land Board.

Program features vary and are subject to current funding availability and eligibility requirements.

Texas State Veterans Homes

Texas operates State Veterans Homes that provide skilled nursing care, rehabilitation, memory care, and long-term care services.

These facilities are available to eligible veterans and, in some circumstances, spouses or surviving spouses.

Admission is based upon medical need, availability, and eligibility requirements.

Texas State Veterans Cemeteries

Eligible veterans, spouses, and certain dependents may qualify for burial in a Texas State Veterans Cemetery.

Benefits may include:

- Burial space
- Opening and closing of the grave
- Perpetual care
- Military honors when eligible
- Memorial services

Families should contact the cemetery directly for eligibility and scheduling information.

Hunting and Fishing Licenses

Texas provides certain hunting and fishing license benefits for qualifying disabled veterans.

Program requirements are established by Texas Parks and Wildlife Department.

Veterans should review current eligibility requirements before applying.

Texas State Parks

Texas veterans may qualify for discounted or complimentary access to certain Texas State Parks depending on current program rules and eligibility.

Outdoor recreation provides opportunities for:

- Hiking
- Camping
- Wildlife viewing
- Fishing
- Family activities
- Physical fitness

Veterans are encouraged to review current Texas Parks and Wildlife policies before visiting.

Hazlewood Act

One of Texas' most valuable education benefits is the Hazlewood Act.

Eligible veterans may receive up to 150 credit hours of tuition exemption at participating Texas public colleges and universities.

Some veterans may also transfer unused education hours to eligible dependent children through the Hazlewood Legacy Program.

Veterans should consult their school's Veterans Affairs Certifying Official regarding eligibility.

Texas Veterans Portal

The State of Texas maintains online resources that help veterans locate available programs, services, forms, and educational materials.

These resources include information regarding:

- Employment
- Education
- Health care
- Mental health
- Business ownership
- Housing
- Recreation
- Benefits

Veterans should use official state websites when researching benefits.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to be 100% disabled to receive Texas benefits?

No. Many Texas benefits are available to veterans with different disability ratings or even without a service-connected disability. Eligibility varies by program.

Can I receive both Texas and federal benefits?

Yes. Many veterans qualify for both federal VA benefits and state of Texas veteran benefits.

How do I know which benefits I qualify for?

Meet with an accredited DAV Chapter 246 Service Officer or the Texas Veterans Commission for an individual benefits review.

Veteran Tip

Many veterans apply for federal benefits but never explore state benefits. Reviewing Texas veteran programs each year may uncover new opportunities for you and your family.

Important Documents to Bring

When applying for Texas veterans benefits, you may be asked to provide:

- DD Form 214
 - Government-issued photo ID
 - Texas driver's license or proof of residency
 - VA disability award letter
 - Property ownership records, if applicable
 - Marriage certificate, if applicable
 - Birth certificates for dependent children, if applicable
-

Quick Reference

Texas Veterans Resources

Texas Veterans Commission

- Benefits assistance
- Employment services
- Education guidance
- Veteran outreach
- Claims assistance

Texas Veterans Land Board

- Home loans
- Land loans
- Home improvement loans
- State Veterans Homes
- State Veterans Cemeteries

Texas Parks and Wildlife Department

- Hunting and fishing license benefits
- State park information

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246

- Benefits counseling

- VA disability claims
- Appeals
- Referrals to state and local veteran resources

Texas proudly supports those who have served. Veterans and their families are encouraged to take full advantage of the benefits made available through the State of Texas in recognition of their military service and sacrifice.

Chapter 15

Community Organizations & Veteran Support Networks

Stronger Together

No veteran should have to navigate life alone.

Across Tarrant County, veteran service organizations, nonprofit agencies, faith-based groups, and community volunteers work together to provide support, fellowship, advocacy, and practical assistance.

Whether you are looking for camaraderie, volunteer opportunities, peer support, recreation, or help during a difficult time, these organizations can help connect you with the veteran community.

Disabled American Veterans (DAV)

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) is dedicated to empowering veterans to lead high-quality lives with respect and dignity.

DAV provides:

- Free VA disability claims assistance
- Appeals assistance
- Benefits counseling

- Transportation programs
- Legislative advocacy
- Volunteer opportunities
- Community outreach
- Veteran support

DAV Chapter 246 proudly serves veterans throughout Tarrant County by helping them access the benefits they earned through military service.

American Legion

The American Legion is one of the nation's largest veterans organizations.

Local American Legion posts offer:

- Veteran advocacy
- Community service
- Youth programs
- Scholarship opportunities
- Memorial ceremonies
- Networking
- Fellowship
- Volunteer opportunities

Membership eligibility is determined by military service requirements established by the organization.

Veterans of Foreign Wars (VFW)

The Veterans of Foreign Wars (VFW) supports veterans through:

- Claims assistance
- Legislative advocacy
- Emergency assistance programs
- Scholarships
- Community service
- Veteran outreach
- Military family support

Local VFW Posts also host community events throughout the year.

Military Order of the Purple Heart

The Military Order of the Purple Heart serves combat-wounded veterans and promotes programs supporting Purple Heart recipients and their families.

Programs may include:

- Veteran advocacy
- Community outreach
- Scholarships
- Youth education
- Legislative support

Membership eligibility is based upon receipt of the Purple Heart Medal.

Team Rubicon

Team Rubicon brings together military veterans and first responders to provide disaster relief throughout the United States and around the world.

Volunteer opportunities include:

- Disaster response
- Emergency management
- Community rebuilding
- Storm recovery
- Logistics
- Leadership development

Many veterans find continued purpose through volunteer service with Team Rubicon.

Team Red, White & Blue (Team RWB)

Team RWB enriches veterans' lives by connecting them through physical fitness, social activities, and community engagement.

Activities may include:

- Running clubs
- Cycling
- Hiking
- Fitness events
- Volunteer projects
- Social gatherings
- Family activities

Participation is open to veterans and community supporters.

The Mission Continues

The Mission Continues empowers veterans to continue serving their communities after military service.

Projects often include:

- Community improvement
- School partnerships
- Neighborhood revitalization
- Disaster recovery
- Volunteer leadership

Veterans continue making a positive impact while building strong community connections.

Military Veteran Peer Network

The Military Veteran Peer Network (MVPN) connects veterans with trained peer volunteers who understand military culture and the transition to civilian life.

Peer support services may include:

- Resource navigation
- Emotional support

- Crisis intervention referrals
- Community engagement
- Recovery support
- Family assistance
- Veteran mentoring

Peer support can be especially valuable for veterans adjusting to civilian life or recovering from difficult experiences.

Faith-Based Veteran Support

Many churches, synagogues, mosques, and faith-based organizations throughout Tarrant County provide support to veterans and military families.

Services may include:

- Food assistance
- Counseling
- Financial assistance
- Support groups
- Volunteer opportunities
- Holiday programs
- Emergency assistance

Participation is open to veterans of all faiths and backgrounds.

Volunteer Opportunities

Many veterans discover renewed purpose through volunteer service.

Volunteer opportunities may include:

- Mentoring fellow veterans
- Driving veterans to medical appointments
- Community clean-up projects
- Disaster response
- Youth mentoring
- Food pantry support

- Hospital volunteer programs
- Honor Guard participation

Serving others often strengthens both the community and the volunteer.

Staying Connected

Isolation can negatively affect both physical and mental health.

Veterans are encouraged to remain active by:

- Attending chapter meetings
- Joining veteran organizations
- Participating in community events
- Volunteering
- Exercising regularly
- Maintaining friendships
- Seeking support when needed

A strong support network contributes to long-term health and well-being.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I have to be disabled to join a veterans organization?

No. Eligibility depends on each organization's membership requirements.

Can my family participate?

Many organizations welcome spouses, children, caregivers, and community volunteers at selected events and programs.

Can I volunteer even if I am retired?

Absolutely. Veterans of every age continue making valuable contributions to their communities through volunteer service.

Veteran Tip

One of the best ways to improve your transition after military service is to stay connected with other veterans. Shared experiences build friendships, provide encouragement, and create opportunities to serve your community in new ways.

Important Contacts

Veterans should keep current contact information for:

- DAV Chapter 246
 - VA North Texas Health Care System
 - Texas Veterans Commission
 - Tarrant County Veterans Service Office
 - Veterans Crisis Line
 - Local emergency contacts
 - Primary care provider
 - Emergency family contacts
-

Quick Reference

Veteran Organizations

Disabled American Veterans (DAV)

- Claims assistance
- Benefits counseling
- Transportation
- Advocacy

American Legion

- Veteran advocacy
- Community service
- Scholarships
- Fellowship

Veterans of Foreign Wars (VFW)

- Veteran support
- Emergency assistance
- Legislative advocacy

Team Rubicon

- Disaster response
- Volunteer opportunities

Team Red, White & Blue

- Fitness
- Community events
- Veteran connections

Military Veteran Peer Network

- Peer mentoring
- Resource navigation
- Emotional support

Military service creates lifelong bonds. The organizations in this chapter provide opportunities to continue serving, build lasting friendships, support fellow veterans, and strengthen the communities we proudly call home.

Chapter 16

Complete Tarrant County Veterans Resource Directory

How to Use This Directory

This directory brings together many of the most frequently used veteran resources serving Tarrant County. While every effort has been made to verify this information, veterans are encouraged to confirm office hours, appointment requirements, and eligibility before visiting.

If you are unsure where to begin, contact **DAV Chapter 246**. An accredited DAV Service Officer can help determine which programs best fit your needs.

Emergency Assistance

Emergency Services

Emergency

- Call **911**

For life-threatening emergencies requiring police, fire, or emergency medical services.

Veterans Crisis Line

Available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.

- Call **988**, then press **1**
- Text **838255**
- Online Chat: www.veteranscrisisline.net

Services include:

- Suicide prevention
 - Mental health crisis intervention
 - Emergency counseling
 - Family support
-

VA Benefits & Claims Assistance

Disabled American Veterans (DAV) Chapter 246

Primary Resource for:

- Initial VA Disability Claims
- PACT Act Claims
- Appeals
- Supplemental Claims
- Higher-Level Reviews
- Survivor Benefits
- Dependency Claims
- VA Benefits Counseling
- Benefits Referrals

Services are provided at no cost to veterans.

Tarrant County Veteran Service Office

Provides assistance with:

- VA benefits information
- County veteran programs
- Burial benefits
- Benefit applications
- Veteran resource referrals

Appointments are recommended.

Texas Veterans Commission

Provides:

- Claims representation
 - Employment services
 - Education assistance
 - Entrepreneur support
 - Veteran outreach
 - Mental health initiatives
-

VA Health Care

VA North Texas Health Care System

Primary services include:

- Primary Care
 - Specialty Care
 - Mental Health
 - Pharmacy
 - Women's Health
 - Telehealth
 - Rehabilitation
 - Social Work
 - Laboratory
 - Radiology
 - Emergency Care
-

Fort Worth VA Clinic

Services include:

- Primary Care
 - Audiology
 - Physical Therapy
 - Laboratory
 - Pharmacy
 - Mental Health
 - Specialty Referrals
 - Preventive Care
-

Fort Worth Vet Center

Provides:

- PTSD Counseling
- Military Sexual Trauma Counseling
- Bereavement Counseling
- Family Counseling
- Transition Assistance
- Readjustment Counseling

- Community Referrals
-

Housing

Organizations assisting veterans experiencing housing instability include:

- HUD-VASH
- Supportive Services for Veteran Families (SSVF)
- Catholic Charities Fort Worth
- Presbyterian Night Shelter
- Volunteers of America Texas
- Patriot House

Available assistance may include:

- Emergency shelter
 - Rental assistance
 - Utility assistance
 - Transitional housing
 - Permanent supportive housing
 - Case management
-

Food Assistance

Resources include:

- Tarrant Area Food Bank
- Mission Arlington
- Salvation Army
- Community Food Pantries
- Meals on Wheels

Programs may provide:

- Emergency groceries
- Mobile food distributions
- Senior nutrition
- Holiday meals

- Household essentials
-

Employment

Organizations serving veterans include:

- Texas Veterans Commission Employment Services
- Workforce Solutions for Tarrant County
- Hire Heroes USA
- Veterans Business Outreach Center

Services include:

- Resume assistance
 - Career coaching
 - Job placement
 - Interview preparation
 - Small business counseling
-

Education

Education resources include:

- GI Bill®
 - Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E)
 - Hazlewood Act
 - Tarrant County College
 - University of Texas at Arlington
 - Texas Wesleyan University
 - Texas Christian University
-

Transportation

Transportation resources include:

- DAV Transportation Network
 - VA Beneficiary Travel
 - Trinity Metro
 - ADA Mobility Services
 - Community Transportation Programs
-

Legal Services

Organizations providing legal assistance include:

- Texas Lawyers for Texas Veterans
- Legal Aid of NorthWest Texas
- Veterans Treatment Courts

Common legal services include:

- Estate Planning
 - Family Law
 - Consumer Protection
 - Housing Issues
 - Employment Rights
-

Mental Health

Resources include:

- Veterans Crisis Line
- VA North Texas Mental Health
- Fort Worth Vet Center
- Military Veteran Peer Network
- Community Counseling Services

Available support includes:

- PTSD treatment
- Depression treatment
- Anxiety treatment
- Substance use recovery

- Peer support
 - Family counseling
-

Women Veterans

Resources include:

- Women Veterans Program Manager
 - Women's Health Services
 - Maternity Care Coordination
 - Military Sexual Trauma Support
 - Preventive Care
-

Senior Veterans

Programs include:

- Home-Based Primary Care
 - Community Living Centers
 - Texas State Veterans Homes
 - Hospice Care
 - Aid and Attendance
 - Homemaker Services
-

Community Organizations

Veterans are encouraged to connect with organizations such as:

- Disabled American Veterans
- American Legion
- Veterans of Foreign Wars
- Military Order of the Purple Heart
- Team Rubicon
- Team Red, White & Blue
- The Mission Continues

- Military Veteran Peer Network
-

Important Documents Checklist

Keep copies of these important documents in a safe place:

- ☐ DD Form 214
 - ☐ VA Disability Decision Letters
 - ☐ Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC)
 - ☐ Social Security Card
 - ☐ Government-Issued Photo Identification
 - ☐ Marriage Certificate
 - ☐ Birth Certificates
 - ☐ Medical Records
 - ☐ Insurance Information
 - ☐ Emergency Contact Information
 - ☐ Current Medication List
 - ☐ Powers of Attorney
 - ☐ Advance Directive
 - ☐ Banking Information for Direct Deposit
-

Quick Action Guide

I Need Help Filing a VA Claim

Contact **DAV Chapter 246** for free accredited claims assistance.

I Need Medical Care

Contact the **VA North Texas Health Care System** or your assigned VA Primary Care Team.

I Am Facing a Mental Health Crisis

Call **988**, then press **1**, or text **838255**.

I Am Facing Homelessness

Contact the **VA Homeless Program, HUD-VASH**, or a local emergency housing provider immediately.

I Need Food

Contact the **Tarrant Area Food Bank, Mission Arlington**, or another local food pantry.

I Need Employment

Contact the **Texas Veterans Commission Employment Services** or **Workforce Solutions for Tarrant County**.

I Don't Know Where to Start

Start with **DAV Chapter 246**.

An accredited Service Officer can help you understand your benefits, explain your options, and connect you with trusted local resources throughout Tarrant County.

Closing Message

Thank You for Your Service

Every benefit described in this guide was earned through your service to our nation.

Whether you served during wartime or peacetime, for four years or thirty, your sacrifice matters.

If you have never applied for your VA benefits, today is the best time to begin.

If you were previously denied, do not assume your journey is over. Laws change, medical evidence evolves, and new opportunities may now be available.

Most importantly, remember that you do not have to navigate the process alone.

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246 is committed to helping veterans, their families, caregivers, and survivors access the benefits they have earned through honorable military service.

Thank you for your service, your sacrifice, and your continued commitment to our community. It is our privilege to serve those who have served our nation.

Appendix A

Top 25 Benefits Every Veteran Should Know

Many veterans are unaware of the full range of benefits available to them. The following checklist highlights some of the most valuable federal, state, and local benefits discussed throughout this guide.

If you are unsure whether you qualify, schedule an appointment with **DAV Chapter 246** for a free benefits review.

Health Care

- ☐ Enroll in VA Health Care if eligible.
 - ☐ Choose a Primary Care Provider.
 - ☐ Learn about specialty care available through VA North Texas.
 - ☐ Register for VA online health management tools.
 - ☐ Ask about telehealth appointments.
-

Disability Benefits

- ☐ File a VA Disability Compensation claim if you have a service-connected illness or injury.
 - ☐ Review eligibility under the PACT Act if you were exposed to toxic substances.
 - ☐ Ask about secondary service-connected conditions.
 - ☐ Request an increased rating if your condition has worsened.
 - ☐ Review your eligibility for Total Disability based on Individual Unemployability (TDIU).
-

Education

- ☐ Apply for GI Bill® education benefits.
 - ☐ Review eligibility for the Texas Hazlewood Act.
 - ☐ Explore Veteran Readiness & Employment (VR&E).
 - ☐ Meet with your school's Veterans Certifying Official.
-

Housing

- ☐ Learn about the VA Home Loan Guaranty Program.
- ☐ Review HUD-VASH housing assistance if you are experiencing homelessness.
- ☐ Explore Texas Veterans Land Board home loan programs.

Financial Benefits

- ☐ Review Texas property tax exemptions.
 - ☐ Ask about Aid and Attendance if you need daily assistance.
 - ☐ Learn about survivor benefits for your family.
-

Employment

- ☐ Register with Texas Veterans Commission Employment Services.
 - ☐ Attend veteran hiring events.
 - ☐ Explore apprenticeship and certification programs.
 - ☐ Learn about Veterans Preference for federal employment.
-

Family Support

- ☐ Ask about VA Caregiver Support Programs.
 - ☐ Learn about survivor benefits.
 - ☐ Keep important documents organized for your family.
-

Community

- ☐ Join a local veteran organization.
 - ☐ Volunteer in your community.
 - ☐ Attend DAV Chapter 246 meetings and outreach events.
-

Appendix B

Frequently Asked Questions

I never served in combat. Can I still qualify for VA benefits?

Yes. Many VA benefits are available regardless of whether a veteran served in combat. Eligibility depends on military service and individual program requirements.

I served many years ago. Is it too late to apply?

No.

Many veterans successfully apply for benefits decades after leaving military service.

I was previously denied.

Should I apply again?

Possibly.

Changes in federal law, new medical evidence, or additional documentation may allow you to qualify now.

Have your previous decision reviewed by DAV Chapter 246 before assuming you are no longer eligible.

Do I need to be a DAV member to receive claims assistance?

No.

DAV provides accredited VA claims assistance regardless of membership.

Does DAV charge for claims assistance?

No.

Accredited DAV claims assistance is provided free of charge.

Never pay anyone who claims they can guarantee VA disability benefits.

How long does a VA claim take?

Processing times vary depending on the complexity of the claim, the evidence submitted, and VA workload.

DAV Chapter 246 can help you understand the process and respond to VA requests for additional information.

What should I bring to my first appointment?

Bring as many of the following as possible:

- DD Form 214
- Government-issued photo ID
- VA correspondence
- Medical records
- Current medication list
- Marriage certificate, if applicable
- Birth certificates for dependent children, if applicable

If you do not have every document, do not delay scheduling your appointment.

Can my spouse attend my appointment?

Yes.

A spouse, caregiver, family member, or trusted friend may attend if you would like assistance during the appointment.

Where should I begin if I have never used VA benefits?

Start by contacting **DAV Chapter 246**.

An accredited Service Officer can review your military service, explain available benefits, and help you develop a plan based on your individual circumstances.

Appendix C

Veteran Preparedness Checklist

Every veteran should maintain a personal records folder containing copies of important documents.

Personal Identification

- ☐ Driver License or State Identification Card
 - ☐ Social Security Card
 - ☐ Passport (if available)
-

Military Records

- ☐ DD Form 214
- ☐ Retirement Orders (if applicable)
- ☐ Military Awards
- ☐ Deployment Records

- ☐ Service Treatment Records
-

VA Documents

- ☐ VA Disability Award Letters
 - ☐ VA Decision Letters
 - ☐ Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC)
 - ☐ Current Benefit Information
-

Medical Information

- ☐ Medication List
 - ☐ Allergies
 - ☐ Primary Care Provider
 - ☐ Specialist Contact Information
 - ☐ Medical Insurance Information
-

Family Documents

- ☐ Marriage Certificate
 - ☐ Birth Certificates
 - ☐ Divorce Decree (if applicable)
 - ☐ Adoption Records
-

Financial Information

- ☐ Banking Information
 - ☐ Life Insurance Policies
 - ☐ Property Deeds
 - ☐ Vehicle Titles
 - ☐ Tax Records
-

Legal Documents

- ☐ Last Will and Testament
 - ☐ Medical Power of Attorney
 - ☐ Durable Power of Attorney
 - ☐ Advance Directive
 - ☐ Emergency Contact List
-

Final Message

Our Promise to Veterans

You served our nation with honor.

This guide was created with one purpose: to help veterans and their families find trusted information, understand available benefits, and connect with organizations dedicated to serving those who have served.

If you have questions about VA disability compensation, health care, education, employment, housing, survivor benefits, or any of the resources described in this guide, do not hesitate to ask for assistance.

No veteran should ever feel they must navigate the system alone.

Disabled American Veterans Chapter 246 is committed to helping veterans, caregivers, and survivors access the benefits they have earned through military service.

On behalf of everyone who contributed to this guide, thank you for your service, your sacrifice, and your continued dedication to our nation.

"Keeping Our Promise to America's Veterans."

Appendix D

Complete Tarrant County Veterans Directory

Department of Veterans Affairs

VA North Texas Health Care System

Address:

4500 S. Lancaster Road
Dallas, TX 75216

Services

- Emergency Care
- Primary Care
- Specialty Care
- Surgery
- Mental Health
- Pharmacy
- Laboratory
- Women's Health
- Rehabilitation
- Social Work

Website

www.va.gov/north-texas-health-care

QR Code

(Official VA website)

Fort Worth VA Clinic

Address

2201 SE Loop 820
Fort Worth, TX 76119

Services

- Primary Care
- Audiology
- Physical Therapy
- Mental Health
- Laboratory
- Pharmacy
- Specialty Referrals

Fort Worth Vet Center

Services

- PTSD Counseling
- Military Sexual Trauma Counseling
- Bereavement Counseling
- Family Counseling
- Readjustment Counseling

VA Benefits

DAV Chapter 246

Primary contact for:

- Disability Claims
- Appeals
- PACT Act
- Toxic Exposure
- Survivor Benefits

Phone:

214-831-0298

Tarrant County Veteran Service Office

Benefits Assistance

Burial Benefits

County Programs

Benefit Referrals

Texas Veterans Commission

Employment

Education

Claims

Entrepreneurship

Mental Health

Housing

HUD-VASH

Rental Assistance

Case Management

Permanent Housing

Supportive Services for Veteran Families

Rapid Rehousing

Rent Assistance

Utility Assistance

Catholic Charities Fort Worth

Emergency Assistance

Food

Housing

Financial Assistance

Presbyterian Night Shelter

Emergency Shelter

Meals

Housing Navigation

Case Management

Volunteers of America Texas

Housing

Employment

Recovery

Case Management

Mental Health

Veterans Crisis Line

988 then Press 1

Text 838255

24 Hours

Military Veteran Peer Network

Peer Support

Mentors

Community Events

VA Mental Health

PTSD

Depression

Anxiety

Substance Use

Telehealth

Employment

Texas Veterans Commission

Workforce Solutions

Hire Heroes USA

Veterans Business Outreach Center

Education

GI Bill®

Hazlewood Act

VR&E

Tarrant County College

UTA

Texas Wesleyan

TCU

Legal

Texas Lawyers for Texas Veterans

Legal Aid of NorthWest Texas

Veterans Treatment Court

Transportation

DAV Transportation

VA Beneficiary Travel

Trinity Metro

ADA Transportation

Emergency Contacts

911

Veterans Crisis Line

Poison Center

Texas 211

DAV Chapter 246

Appendix E

Maps

This section will include professionally designed maps showing:

- VA North Texas Health Care System
- Fort Worth VA Clinic
- Fort Worth Vet Center
- Tarrant County Veteran Service Office
- DAV Chapter 246
- Major housing resources
- Food assistance locations
- Employment resources
- Legal aid offices
- Transportation routes

Each map will have:

- Address
 - Parking information
 - Nearby highways
 - Public transportation
 - QR code for GPS navigation
-

Appendix F

QR Code Directory

Every major resource in the guide will include a QR code linking directly to the official website.

Examples include:

Department of Veterans Affairs

- Health Care Enrollment
- Disability Compensation
- PACT Act Information
- VA Forms
- My HealtheVet
- VA.gov

Texas Veterans Commission

- Benefits
- Employment
- Education
- Grants

Texas Veterans Land Board

- Home Loans
- Land Loans
- Veterans Homes
- Veterans Cemeteries

DAV

- Find a DAV Office
- Chapter Information
- Claims Assistance

Tarrant County

- Veteran Services
- Emergency Assistance
- Community Resources

Veterans Crisis Line

- Call
- Text
- Online Chat

Appendix G

Emergency Quick Reference Guide

This page is designed to be printed on the inside front cover or as a detachable insert.

If You Need...

Medical Emergency

Call **911**

Mental Health Crisis

Veterans Crisis Line

Call **988**, then press **1**

Text **838255**

VA Disability Claim

Contact **DAV Chapter 246**

Free Accredited Claims Assistance

Phone: **214-831-0298**

Medical Care

VA North Texas Health Care System

Primary Care

Urgent Care

Specialty Care

Housing

HUD-VASH

Supportive Services for Veteran Families

Catholic Charities Fort Worth

Presbyterian Night Shelter

Food

Tarrant Area Food Bank

Mission Arlington

Salvation Army

Employment

Texas Veterans Commission

Workforce Solutions

Hire Heroes USA

Transportation

DAV Transportation Network

VA Beneficiary Travel

Trinity Metro

Appendix H

Glossary of Veterans Terms

Many veterans encounter unfamiliar terms when applying for benefits. This glossary provides plain-language explanations of common VA and military terms.

Accredited Service Officer (ASO)

A trained and accredited representative authorized to assist veterans with VA benefits and disability claims at no cost.

Agent Orange

A tactical herbicide used during the Vietnam War. Eligible veterans exposed to Agent Orange may qualify for VA disability benefits for certain presumptive conditions.

Appeal

A request asking the VA to review a decision because you disagree with the outcome.

Buddy Statement

A written statement from someone who served with you or has firsthand knowledge of your injury, illness, or symptoms.

C&P Examination

A Compensation and Pension examination requested by the VA to evaluate a claimed disability.

DD Form 214

The official military discharge document. It is one of the most important records veterans should keep.

DBQ (Disability Benefits Questionnaire)

A standardized medical form used by health care providers to document symptoms and medical findings for VA disability claims.

Dependency and Indemnity Compensation (DIC)

A monthly benefit available to certain surviving spouses, children, or parents of deceased veterans.

Effective Date

The date the VA determines benefits begin. It affects the amount of retroactive compensation a veteran may receive.

GI Bill®

Federal education benefits available to eligible veterans and service members.

Higher-Level Review

A review of an existing VA decision by a more experienced claims reviewer without submitting new evidence.

Hazlewood Act

A Texas education benefit providing tuition exemptions for eligible veterans at Texas public colleges and universities.

Military Sexual Trauma (MST)

Sexual assault or repeated threatening sexual harassment experienced during military service.

Nexus Letter

A medical opinion connecting a current disability to military service.

PACT Act

Federal legislation expanding health care and disability benefits for veterans exposed to toxic substances.

Presumptive Condition

A condition that the VA automatically presumes is connected to military service for qualifying veterans.

Secondary Service Connection

A disability caused or worsened by another service-connected condition.

Service Connection

Recognition by the VA that a disability resulted from military service.

Supplemental Claim

A request to reopen a claim using new and relevant evidence.

TDIU

Total Disability based on Individual Unemployability. Eligible veterans may receive compensation at the 100% rate even if their combined disability rating is less than 100%.

TERA

Toxic Exposure Risk Activity, a category used by the VA when evaluating certain toxic exposure claims.

Veteran Health Identification Card (VHIC)

An identification card issued to eligible veterans enrolled in VA health care.

Appendix I

Common VA Forms

Form	Purpose
VA Form 21-526EZ	Apply for disability compensation
VA Form 20-0995	Supplemental Claim
VA Form 20-0996	Higher-Level Review
VA Form 10182	Board Appeal
VA Form 21-686c	Add or remove dependents

VA Form 10-10EZ Enroll in VA Health Care

VA Form 21P-534EZ Survivor benefits (DIC, death pension, accrued benefits)

Always use the latest version of each form available on the official U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs website.

Appendix J

Veterans Benefits by Life Stage

Recently Separated Veterans

Priority Checklist:

- Obtain your DD Form 214.
 - Enroll in VA Health Care.
 - File disability claims if applicable.
 - Update your contact information with the VA.
 - Explore GI Bill® benefits.
 - Meet with DAV Chapter 246.
-

Veterans Starting College

Priority Checklist:

- Apply for GI Bill® benefits.
- Meet with the school's Veterans Certifying Official.
- Explore Hazlewood Act eligibility.
- Apply for scholarships.
- Register with campus Veteran Services.

Veterans Buying a Home

Priority Checklist:

- Review VA Home Loan eligibility.
 - Explore Texas Veterans Land Board home loans.
 - Apply for property tax exemptions if eligible.
 - Review homeowner insurance options.
-

Veterans Starting a Business

Priority Checklist:

- Meet with the Veterans Business Outreach Center.
 - Develop a business plan.
 - Register your business.
 - Learn about veteran-owned business certifications.
 - Explore financing opportunities.
-

Senior Veterans

Priority Checklist:

- Review Aid and Attendance eligibility.
 - Explore Home-Based Primary Care.
 - Complete advance directives.
 - Organize important records.
 - Review long-term care options.
-

Family Caregivers

Priority Checklist:

- Contact the VA Caregiver Support Program.
- Explore respite care.

- Organize medical records.
 - Build a support network.
 - Learn about survivor benefits.
-

Surviving Spouses

Priority Checklist:

- Request multiple certified copies of the death certificate.
 - Contact DAV Chapter 246.
 - Review Dependency and Indemnity Compensation (DIC).
 - Apply for burial benefits.
 - Review education benefits.
-

Appendix K

Annual Veterans Planning Calendar

January

- Review VA disability rating.
 - Organize important documents.
 - Update emergency contacts.
-

February

- Schedule annual wellness visits.
 - Review prescription medications.
-

March

- Prepare for property tax exemption deadlines.
 - Review employment goals.
-

April

- Organize financial records.
 - Meet with a benefits counselor if needed.
-

May

- Attend Memorial Day ceremonies.
 - Volunteer with local veteran organizations.
-

June

- Review hurricane and severe weather preparedness plans.
 - Update emergency supply kits.
-

July

- Review education benefits before the fall semester.
 - Update caregiver information.
-

August

- Prepare children for the new school year.
 - Review scholarship opportunities.
-

September

- Attend local veteran outreach events.
 - Review PACT Act eligibility.
-

October

- Get recommended vaccinations.
 - Schedule annual preventive screenings.
-

November

- Participate in Veterans Day events.
 - Review changes to VA benefits for the coming year.
-

December

- Update wills and advance directives.
 - Organize tax documents.
 - Review accomplishments and goals for the new year.
-